

Nausea



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF JEAN-PAUL SARTRE

Jean-Paul Sartre was born in Paris in 1905. His father, a French Navy officer, died when Sartre was a young boy, and his mother consequently moved the family to Meudon, her own childhood home. Sartre was educated well the tutelage of his maternal grandfather, and he began to form an interest in philosophy early in life. He later attended elite Parisian schools: the Cours Hattemer and the École Normale Supérieure. At the latter of these institutions, he met Simone de Beauvoir, and the two eventually entered a non-exclusive romantic relationship as she became a rising star at the Sorbonne. After attaining an excellent score on his exams at the École Normale Supérieure, Sartre went on to teach at various lycées (schools for children 15-18, roughly equivalent to high school) around France. While teaching in La Havre from 1931 to 1936, he wrote *Nausea*. Sartre was drafted into World War II, during which he spent nine months as a German prisoner of war. Upon returning to France, he joined socialist groups and participated in underground rebellion against German occupation, sometimes authoring essays and articles for resistance newspapers. After the war, he wrote several pieces about antisemitism, racism, and hatred. Throughout the later years of his life, Sartre dedicated himself to activism over writing, even getting arrested for civil disobedience in 1968. He died in 1980 of a pulmonary edema. After his death, it became well known that Sartre, in tandem with de Beauvoir, had exhibited a pattern of grooming and sexually pursuing young teen girls.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Nausea, published in 1938, was written during the period between World War I and World War II. In the novel, the Self-Taught Man describes his experience fighting in World War I, in which he was taken prisoner in a German camp for two years. He was taken captive in 1917 and released in 1919, just after the end of the war in November 1918. The four-year war spanned the globe and was one of the most devastating events in human history. It was known at the time as the “Great War,” a name that suggests just how great the scale of human suffering was compared to anything the world had seen previously. Against this backdrop, philosophical movements like nihilism and humanism flourished and clashed with one another, and *Nausea* stakes its place in this landscape. Published on the eve of World War II (1939-1945), another global conflict which shocked and shook the faith of much of the world, it also unwittingly anticipates even greater crises of existence and meaning.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Nausea is frequently compared to Albert Camus’s [The Stranger](#) (1942), another philosophical novel originally published in French. Its protagonist, Meursault, moves through life with an apathy reminiscent of Roquentin’s. Although Camus himself did not conceive of [The Stranger](#) as an Existentialist work, critics have often labelled it such, particularly due to the fact that Camus and Sartre were acquaintances who both published essays on each other’s work. For more Existentialist writings, one might read some of Sartre’s other works, of which the foremost among them might be the play [No Exit](#) (1944) and the novel *The Age of Reason* (1945). Sartre’s lover and contemporary, Simone de Beauvoir, was also a major 20th-century French academic, writer, and philosopher. Her magnum opus *The Second Sex* (1949) explores the central thesis of *Nausea* through a feminist lens, outlining the historical oppression of women and asserting that women are as capable of transcending their circumstances and choosing their own destinies as their male counterparts. Rainer Maria Rilke’s *The Notebooks of Malte Laurids Brigge* (1910) anticipates *Nausea*’s first-person narrative full of impressionistic prose, contemplation of the human condition, and observation of city rhythms. Finally, those looking for a more modern take on Existentialist themes might enjoy Marie NDiaye’s *My Heart Hemmed In* (2017), a contemporary French novel in which a woman finds herself the subject of xenophobic disgust and slowly descends into despair.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Nausea*
- **When Written:** Around 1936
- **Where Written:** Le Havre, France
- **When Published:** April 1938
- **Literary Period:** Existentialism
- **Genre:** Philosophical Novel
- **Setting:** The fictional city of Bouville, France
- **Climax:** Roquentin experiences an ecstatic revelation in the park and learns the secret of existence.
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Cameo. Crabs, a major motif in *Nausea*, tend to appear in Roquentin’s mind when he’s at his most disconnected from reality. In 1935, Sartre experimented with mescaline—a psychedelic similar to LSD—and saw visions of crabs for weeks afterward!

A City Novel. It's commonly thought that Sartre based Roquentin's fictional city of Bouville on Le Havre, where Sartre was working as a philosophy teacher at the time.



PLOT SUMMARY

An "Editors' Note" states that the following diary was discovered among the belongings of Antoine Roquentin, who had moved to the fictional city of Bouville in order to finish his historical research on the Marquis de Rollebon after years of extensive travel. In a set of undated pages, Roquentin records the events of his day. After a strange incident in which Roquentin picked up a stone to throw it in the sea and then found himself unexplainably repulsed by it, Roquentin is trying to write down his observations in order to ground himself. As he writes, he reassures himself that he has nothing to worry about.

An unspecified amount of time later, Roquentin's dated diary entries begin. He is now sure that he has a problem. He finds himself unable to recognize things that he sees frequently, and he has started to feel disgusted and overwhelmed by inanimate objects, a condition that he calls "Nausea." As his loneliness worsens, Roquentin starts to miss his ex-lover, Anny. He tries to throw himself into his work on the Marquis de Rollebon, but he realizes that he doesn't care about the Marquis as much as he used to. The only thing that comforts him is his favorite record, which he listens to at the *Rendezvous des Cheminots*.

Roquentin starts to pay more attention to the Self-Taught Man, a fellow patron of the library who he realizes is trying to read all the library's books in alphabetical order. The Self-Taught Man asks Roquentin to show him pictures from his travels, which prompts Roquentin to think about adventure. Listening to the Self-Taught Man talk about the excitement of adventure, Roquentin starts to think that he himself has never had one, even after six years of travel. The thought bothers him more and more. Amid his growing dissatisfaction with his work on the Marquis, Roquentin tries to touch Françoise, the owner of the *Rendezvous des Cheminots* with whom he sometimes has casual sex. As he touches her genitals, however, he's overcome with disgust and images of an overgrown **garden**.

Roquentin receives a short letter from Anny asking him to come visit her while she is in Paris in a few weeks. At first, Roquentin is not very excited to go, but as his Nausea worsens, he starts to look forward to the meeting hopefully. Roquentin finally gives up on writing about the Marquis de Rollebon, unable to get past his conviction that the book has become the only "justification" for his existence. Roquentin grows increasingly conscious of his own existence, and he starts to wonder what the point of his life is.

The Self-Taught Man invites Roquentin to lunch. Roquentin, relieved to have some human interaction, accepts. As the two of

them talk, Roquentin learns that the Self-Taught Man is a humanist and a socialist, having fallen in love with humankind after being held prisoner in a German camp for two years during World War I. The Self-Taught Man presses Roquentin about humanism, and Roquentin uncomfortably deflects. Having encountered humanists many times in the past, Roquentin does not hold the same views as the Self-Taught Man, but he's wary of offending him. When the Self-Taught Man tries to insist that Roquentin is a humanist at heart, Roquentin feels a wave of Nausea and runs from the restaurant as the other patrons stare at him.

Full of Nausea, Roquentin makes his way to the Bouville public park, where he has a revelation. He learns the secret of existence, and everything finally starts to make sense to him. Quickly, though, he becomes overwhelmed again as he realizes that the world seemingly exists for no reason at all. Like all else, Roquentin has done nothing to deserve or earn his own existence—he just exists. Feeling fed up with Bouville now that he's given up his old reason for existing, the Marquis de Rollebon, Roquentin decides to move to Paris after he visits Anny.

Roquentin arrives at Anny's hotel room in Paris, and she greets him with callous familiarity. Anny tells Roquentin that she has changed. Back when the two of them were together, she used to constantly pursue "perfect moments": situations so remarkable it was as though they were taken from a play or a book. Like Roquentin's sense of adventure, perfect moments were how Anny processed her awareness of the passage of time, which in her mind was what made life special and worth living. But now, she tells Roquentin, she can't feel those moments anymore. She, too, has no more reason to be alive, and she lives in her memories of the past. Anny lives comfortably as a mistress, but she's not happy. Roquentin tries to convince her to join him in his new life in Paris, but she flatly refuses, bidding him goodbye. The next day, Roquentin watches her leave Paris on a train with her lover.

Feeling lonelier than ever, Roquentin returns to Bouville for a few more days before he moves to Paris. At the library, the Self-Taught Man is caught inappropriately touching a young male student under a table in the reading room. Roquentin watches it happen, feeling sympathy for the Self-Taught Man, but when the Corsican guard of the reading room starts to beat the Self-Taught Man, Roquentin intervenes. The Self-Taught Man runs away immediately.

Later, Roquentin goes to the *Rendezvous des Cheminots* to say goodbye to Françoise. Madeline, the waitress, puts on his favorite record. As he listens to the music, Roquentin realizes that he can justify his own existence by writing a novel. Like the melody he hears, a novel can be a pure act of creation that doesn't depend on the existence of other things, and writing one would allow Roquentin himself to live on even after he no longer exists. Roquentin resolves to write the novel, and night

falls.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Antoine Roquentin – Roquentin is the protagonist of *Nausea*. After a strange incident in which he finds himself unable to touch a stone without feeling assaulted by its existence, he starts to record his experiences in a diary. Over the course of the story, Roquentin falls gradually deeper into the grasp of a sensation that he calls “Nausea”: the awareness of existence unfiltered by the perception of essence. As he works through these feelings, he begins to wonder what the point of his own existence. For six years prior to arriving in Bouville, Roquentin travelled the world extensively in search of adventure. Seeing the world and dating his hot-and-cold girlfriend Anny, Roquentin was satisfied until he abruptly became disgusted by his life and decided to write a historical study of the Marquis de Rollebon. As *Nausea* progresses, Roquentin becomes disenchanted with Rollebon, too. He realizes that all his work on his book has been worthless, since he has allowed Rollebon to take control of his life. Even when Roquentin is working on his book, though, it seems like he has enough money that he doesn’t need to do anything—and this is partially why he’s so aimless. Well-educated, well-travelled, and mysteriously wealthy, Roquentin still can’t find happiness or meaning in his life. He is desperately lonely, but generally disdainful of the people around him, as if he’s set apart from humanity entirely. At the end of the novel, Roquentin finds a solution to his woes: he resolves to write a novel in order to justify his own existence.

The Self-Taught Man – The Self-Taught Man is an unnamed patron of the Bouville library, although an editor’s footnote that begins the novel identifies him as a bailiff’s clerk named Ogier. Roquentin often sees him in the reading room. For seven years, the Self-Taught Man has been working toward his ultimate goal: to read every book in the library from A to Z. In Roquentin’s early conversations with the Self-Taught Man, he learns that the Self-Taught Man admires Roquentin’s experience abroad. Despite all the books he’s read within the confines of the Bouville library’s reading room, the Self-Taught Man longs for “adventure.” He also looks up to Roquentin’s work on his book, and over their shared lunch, it appears that the Self-Taught Man struggles to write his own lines without thinking of what other authors have already written. In fact, the Self-Taught Man tells Roquentin that he doesn’t want to write anything original, but would rather write something he knows is “true” because someone else has already expressed it. As Roquentin learns over lunch, The Self-Taught Man served in the French army during World War I and became a prisoner of war in a German camp. While captive in crowded conditions, he fell in love with humanity, ultimately coming to identify as a

humanist and a socialist. Throughout *Nausea*, Roquentin tends to see the Self-Taught Man as an innocent, almost childlike figure. As a result, Roquentin sympathizes with the Self-Taught Man when the Corsican guard catches him in the act of groping a young male student. To Roquentin, the Self-Taught Man is a victim of his own unconventional “love” and loneliness.

Anny – Anny is Roquentin’s ex-lover, whom he hasn’t seen for four years. Anny and Roquentin travelled the world together and apart, reuniting in hotel rooms when they could. Anny briefly worked as an actress in stage plays in London. Now, she travels in luxury as a mistress to rich men. She and Roquentin reunite after she sends him a letter, begging him to come visit her in Paris. At their meeting, she eagerly informs him that she has changed: no more the demanding, idealistic girl who sought to make everything a “perfect moment,” Anny is now a tired and disillusioned woman. Just as Roquentin has lost his sense of adventure, Anny is no longer able to sense perfect moments. In her pursuit of perfect moments, Anny was often irritable, cruel, and morose with Roquentin, who never knew how to satisfy her desires. Now that Anny can no longer pursue perfect moments at all, she lives in the past, using the force of her imagination to relieve the perfect moments that have passed her by. Like Roquentin, she feels that she has no reason to live—and unlike Roquentin, she doesn’t think that reigniting their romantic relationship could give her a reason to go on. Instead, Roquentin watches her leave for Egypt with her new lover, knowing that neither of them is happy, but that they can’t solve each other’s problems, either.

Monsieur Fasquelle – Monsieur Fasquelle owns the Café Mably, a restaurant that Roquentin frequents. Fasquelle is attentive to his customers during the busiest parts of the day, but when business slows down in the afternoon, he tends to go to sleep. Roquentin associates his behavior with loneliness, suggesting that Fasquelle relies on interactions with other people for energy. On a **foggy** Friday, Roquentin goes to Café Mably for breakfast and finds that Fasquelle has not yet come downstairs to serve his customers. After a woman makes a throwaway comment insinuating that Fasquelle might be dead, Roquentin gradually becomes frantic imagining that this is the case. After he is unable to convince the Café Mably waiter to go upstairs and check on Fasquelle, Roquentin becomes convinced that Fasquelle is dead. The thought sends Roquentin into a tailspin, worsened by the foggy weather, until he later finds out that Fasquelle has merely fallen ill with the flu.

Lucie – Lucie is the charwoman (or cleaning lady) of the Hotel Printania, where Roquentin lives. Early in the novel, he encounters her cleaning the stairs and talking to the proprietress on his way out of the hotel. Roquentin overhears Lucie complaining about her husband Charles, a younger and better-looking man who Roquentin suspects married Lucie for her money. Lucie talks about her marital troubles in a distant, reasonable way, even suggesting that her husband should see

other women. When Roquentin later encounters her and Charles on the street at night, however, Lucie's misery transforms her entire appearance. Even after Charles speaks roughly to her, she desperately begs him to stay with her, suggesting that she's not as indifferent as she pretended to be earlier. During both incidents, Lucie touches her hand to her throat, as if grief and loneliness are choking her.

Françoise – Françoise is the owner of the *Rendezvous des Cheminots*, a bar and restaurant that Roquentin visits often. She and Roquentin are in a very casual, low-commitment sexual relationship. According to Roquentin, Françoise also takes many other lovers, needing to have “a man a day.” Their encounters are devoid of any romantic feelings to the point of being transactional and businesslike in tone, and throughout the novel, Roquentin seems to grow increasingly disgusted with the sex as his Nausea worsens. At one point, Roquentin is beset with vivid images of a **garden** full of grotesque beasts as he touches Françoise's genitals. It is unclear whether Roquentin expresses his distaste internally or externally, but in either case, Françoise remains neutral and unflappable. At the end of the novel, Roquentin and Françoise part ways politely, and she tells him that he should reach out to her if he finds himself in Bouville again.

The Corsican Guard – The guard of the Bouville library's reading room, whom Roquentin calls only “the Corsican,” watches over the library's patrons and materials. Early in the novel, Roquentin notices that the guard seems particularly suspicious of the Self-Taught Man, but when he asks the Self-Taught Man about it at dinner, he deflects. When the guard catches the Self-Taught Man molesting a young male student under a table in the library, the nature of their conflict becomes clear. The guard has seen the Self-Taught Man engaging in inappropriate behavior with children before, but this incident has given him both proof and abundant witnesses. According to Roquentin, the guard likes to think of himself as a protector and taskmaster to the students who visit the library, and as such he takes particularly extreme offense to the Self-Taught Man's violation. When the Guard begins to beat the Self-Taught Man and Roquentin intervenes, the Guard calls him a “fairy,” a slur for gay men that implies that the Guard's disgust with the Self-Taught Man is due to the victim's being not just a child, but a male child.

Charles – Charles is the husband of Lucie, the charwoman at the Hotel Printania. A factory worker, he is young, handsome, and poor. According to Roquentin, Charles married the older and less attractive Lucie for her money, but their marriage is unhappy. Although Charles doesn't beat Lucie or cheat on her with other women, he drinks constantly, and Roquentin believes that he may have tuberculosis. Roquentin encounters Charles and Lucie on the street at night, and watches as Charles speaks cruelly to her and pushes her before leaving her on the sidewalk alone.

Achille – Achille is a small, nervous man who enters a restaurant shortly after Roquentin and begins to hassle the waitress. When she serves him slowly and inattentively, Achille tries to make himself look more important by insisting that she call him “Monsieur Achille” and condescending to her, but she quickly takes offense and starts to ignore him even more. Achille grows more agitated, staring at both the waitress and Roquentin. Roquentin identifies with Achille, recognizing a loneliness that verges on madness in him. Achille only calms down when Doctor Rogé, a man who bears himself with the confidence and experience of someone who has a family and a well-regarded profession, enters and jokingly calls him “crazy.”

Doctor Rogé – Doctor Rogé is a patron of the restaurant where Roquentin and Achille are separately having lunch. When he enters, he greets the assembled patrons warmly and makes easy conversation with the waitress. Noticing his worn and finely wrinkled face, Roquentin identifies him as a man of experience: someone who has served his community, married, and had children. Roquentin reacts to Doctor Rogé defensively, refusing to laugh along with his jokes, while Achille relaxes in his presence. Ultimately, Roquentin comforts himself by concluding that Doctor Rogé will die soon as a result of his full life.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Madeleine – Madeleine is the waitress at the *Rendezvous des Cheminots*.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



EXISTENCE VS. ESSENCE

In his novel *Nausea*, Sartre makes an argument that becomes a central tenet of his philosophy:

Existence precedes essence. In other words, before

an object can have an essence (*what* it is), it has an existence (*that* it is). Sartre's thesis is one of the founding principles of Existentialism, a 20th-century philosophy that explores the implications of human existence with a focus on choice and free will. In general, Existentialists like Sartre suggest that humankind's subjective perception of the world interacts only with its outer layer, essence. When one sees a stone, for example, one sees it as just that—a stone, not the pure “presence” that the stone embodies. If one continues to examine the stone, however, there are more ways to describe it and capture its meaning than one can ever fully realize. In the

novel, the protagonist Roquentin's "Nausea"—the term he uses to describe the sense of discomfort he has suddenly begin to experience—stems from the disintegration of this barrier in his consciousness. He begins to lose his ability to focus on *what* things are and becomes overwhelmed by the abundance *that* things are—that is, existence floods his consciousness and displaces essence. *Nausea*, then, which is presented as a series of Roquentin's journal entries, follows Roquentin's struggle to understand this phenomenon and his gradual acceptance of existence, including his own. It first begins when Roquentin begins to feel repulsed by common objects like the stone and the piece of paper. When he goes to touch them, he finds himself subdued by a fear that he can't name, but which he later comes to associate with the Nausea's sickening awareness of existence. Soon, Roquentin's Nausea extends to his own self-perception as he confronts the bare fact of his existence for the first time after years of travel and research. Unable to find any meaning or purpose in his own life, Roquentin is forced to come to terms with his own existence before he can ever hope to achieve essence.



TIME

Nausea posits that time is relative and subjective. This contradicts the usual way people typically think of time: normally, one makes sense of time

using absolute units of seconds, minutes, hours, and so on. But Sartre conceives of the *experience* of time as important in its own right. *Nausea*, which takes the form of a series of Roquentin's diary entries, forces its reader to confront Roquentin's adventures as he records them, in irregular bursts, odd intervals, and uneven lengths. It's a format that highlights how personal and subjective the experience of time can be. Roquentin exaggerates the idea further in his recollections of his bouts of so-called Nausea, which frequently extend, skip, or otherwise tamper with time as his own perception of its passage grows scrambled. As he watches an old woman walk down the street, for instance, he compares her shuffling gait to time itself, feeling the passage of two eternities as she slowly makes her way. Roquentin and Anny (Roquentin's former lover) both encounter a feeling of having lost the sense of time's irreversibility that they had in their youth. Roquentin comprehends this feeling through his sense of "adventure," while Anny makes sense of it through her appreciation for "perfect moments." Although on the scale of objective time Roquentin and Anny have both aged at a steady pace, they've only now begun to feel old—and this heightened awareness of time's subjectivity is a crucial part of their struggle to find meaning. *Nausea* suggests, then, that the awareness of time's subjective passage is necessary to a rewarding, meaningful life and that living in the past or in the future is not sustainable. In order to live a meaningful life, a person must confront the subjective nature of time. Ignoring time's subjectivity and

instead finding meaning only in one's memories or in one's hopes for the future, the novel suggests, only exacerbates one's feelings of existential dread.



LOVE AND SEXUALITY

Most of the major arcs in *Nausea* involve love and sexuality: Roquentin reunites with his former lover, Anny, for instance. The novel also features a

nefarious sexual encounter in the library between the Self-Taught Man and the brown-haired boy. Although the novel presents love and sexuality in a variety of forms, all these instances have one thing in common: none of them seems to end well. In this way, then, *Nausea* suggests that normative notions of love, sex, and relationships are not fulfilling, meaningful experiences—in fact, they function as barriers to a "free" and meaningful life.

As the novel opens, Roquentin is largely free—of regular working hours, of material worries, and most of all of Anny—but he isn't happy about it. As a result, Anny's letter fills him with hope of reconciliation, and he hopes that reigniting his familiar relationship with her might soothe the Nausea that plagues him. He goes to her and offers her his love (at least, what he thinks is love), but Anny's response keeps them apart. Although Roquentin is willing to try rekindling their relationship in order to escape his suffocating loneliness, Anny is not. Even though she's aging and lonely, too, she prefers the "perfect" Roquentin of her doctored memory to the present Roquentin in front of her. When she tells Roquentin that he hasn't "found [her] again" as he claims, it becomes clear neither of them has really come to terms with who the other (or themselves) is—and thus, getting back together can't be the solution to their search for meaning. Anny's resolute rejection of Roquentin thus drives home the book's broader position on the hindrance that love and sexuality pose to a person's quest for meaning and personal fulfillment.



ART AND LEGACY

After many thought-provoking encounters with art in *Nausea*, Roquentin finally finds hope for an antidote to his suffering in his aspiration to write a

novel that will "make people ashamed of their existence." This conclusion to the story suggests that art—at least in some forms, like music and novels—endows the artist with a legacy that transcends existence itself. Throughout *Nausea*, Roquentin interacts with art forms that are heavily contingent on things that have existed in the past. He frequently passes the statue of Impétra, a sculpture of a historical figure. He confronts the portraits in the Bouville museum, all of which depict real people. And most significantly, he has dedicated his life to writing a history of the Marquis de Rollebon, an 18th-century aristocrat. Roquentin's eventual disenchantment with the Marquis (and his immediate dislike of the other art forms)

signals his awakening to the world of existence: he realizes that he has allowed the Marquis's existence to supersede his own and that he has, in a sense, "loaned him [his] life."

Now alert to his own existence, Roquentin seeks something that can justify it and cleanse it, and he finally finds it by doing the only thing that soothes his Nausea: listening to "Some of these days," a jazz record. Roquentin realizes that the melody of the song, which is separate from the record that makes it play, is not "real." The song affords its composer and singer a legacy untarnished by existence in that they are substantiated only by the echo of the thing they've created. Ultimately, this encounter with the record leads Roquentin to conclude that artists—people who create, not just depict or record—can leave behind the legacy of essence without the baggage of existence.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



CRABS

In Roquentin's most paranoid fantasies, crabs represent Roquentin himself: scuttling and unnatural, on the edge of total madness. Crabs first appear in Roquentin's narrative when he remembers a man he encountered during his childhood. The man used to sit in the Luxembourg **gardens** and stare at his own foot for long periods of time, as if he were afraid of it. Once, when Roquentin and his friends went to the garden to play, the man smiled at one of Roquentin's friends and stretched out his arms as if to embrace him. The children were terrified, and Roquentin remembers their fear as stemming from their certainty that the man was "shaping thoughts of crab or lobster in his head." The thought that the man could be having visions of things so divorced from the real world of the garden was frightening to the children.

As a Nausea-stricken adult, Roquentin remembers this incident and wonders whether he's heading down the same path as the man in the Luxembourg gardens. Throughout much of the novel, Roquentin fears that he is going insane, and that like the man in the garden, he will become completely isolated and rejected by society. The image of the crab returns when Roquentin gives up on writing his historical study of the Marquis de Rollebon. Crushed by his perception of existence, Roquentin looks down at his hand and sees a crab in its place—just as the man in the garden looked at his foot and thought of crabs and lobsters. The incident symbolizes Roquentin's further detachment from reality and from human society. Things take a decided turn for the worse when Roquentin suffers a minor mental breakdown at the end of his meal with the Self-Taught Man. Imagining his entire self as the crab crawling backward in escape, Roquentin throws down his

knife and runs out of the restaurant while everyone stares at him. By this point in the novel, Roquentin's internal alienation from the rest of humanity has surpassed that of the man in the garden, and he feels utterly insane and unnatural, and the crab symbolism reinforces this point.



FOG

To Roquentin, fog is a powerful symbol of derealization, the meaninglessness of existence, and the social alienation Roquentin ultimately suffers as a result. Heightening Roquentin's sense of oblivion, loneliness, and confusion, the fog makes him completely uncertain of how objects relate to one another in physical space. Everything seems elevated and on the brink of metamorphosis. Roquentin is deeply threatened by this sensation, which begins as a literal fog: he wakes one day and finds that the city of Bouville is blanketed in mist. For once, the thing that's frightening Roquentin seems to affect everybody in the city. Monsieur Fasquelle stays in bed, café customers complain about the weather, and the reading room patrons all seem to be reluctant to leave the safety of the library. Roquentin gets progressively more upset as the day continues, until he believes that Fasquelle may be dead and that the library is transforming around him. His experience ceases to be a shared one when he starts to have visions of the fog inside of the library, making everything around him look uncertain and unfamiliar. There, it ceases to be literal and becomes entirely figurative, representing Roquentin's internal confusion.



GARDENS

In *Nausea*, gardens represent sexuality and possibility, both threatening and enlightening. In one of the novel's most striking passages, Roquentin imagines a grotesquely lush garden while touching Françoise's thigh and genitals. As his hand moves up her thigh, he's assaulted by images of ants and centipedes scuttling through "immense hairy leaves," horrifying animal hybrids lurking around every bit of foliage. He then pictures the statue of Velleda, which stands in Bouville's public park, pointing a finger at her own genitals. The imagery seems to be brought on by Roquentin's intense disgust and disinterest in Françoise at this moment, which he disregards in favor of going through the motions of intimacy. It's hard not to relate his landscape of insects crawling through hairy growth to Françoise's pubic hair, and what might be either an anxiety of or a real encounter with a sexual transmitted disease like pubic lice. But the scene also suggests Roquentin's broader distaste for sexual relations that mimic intimacy without any genuine romance. As in other parts of his life, Roquentin's growing sense of existential dread leaves him feeling disillusioned with and horribly alienated from others, and he can no longer tactfully simulate intimacy with Françoise.

Throughout the rest of the novel, Roquentin witnesses and participates in scenes of variously literal sexuality that take place in Bouville's public garden. On the day of the thick **fog**, for instance, Roquentin watches a man in a blue cape lure a little girl in the garden and attempt to flash her. For a moment before she runs away, she seems to meet the man's eyes in a daring manner. Like Roquentin's encounter with Françoise, this incident twists sexuality into something threatening and perverse. Thus, when Roquentin experiences an ecstatic revelation of the secret of existence at the climax of the novel, the reader is primed to think of it in a way that's almost sexual, almost unpleasant. In the lush world of the garden's growth, Roquentin embraces the full possibility of his perception.

closest thing he has to a colleague is the Self-Taught Man, and Roquentin feels set apart even from him.

But Roquentin also reveals a certain aloofness in this quotation, as he implies that his aloneness stems largely from his unwillingness (or inability) to initiate conversation with others. This passage sets up a conflict for Roquentin that dogs him throughout *Nausea*: he craves companionship, but he has a tendency to look down on the people around him. If, as he suggests here, existence is defined through relationships to others, then Roquentin stands to fade increasingly out of existence as he grows more and more isolated.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the New Directions edition of *Nausea* published in 2013.

Chapter 4: Tuesday, 30 January Quotes

☞ There are still about twenty customers left, bachelors, small-time engineers, office employees. They eat hurriedly in boarding-houses which they call their "*popotes*" and since they need a little luxury, they come here after their meals. They drink a cup of coffee and play poker dice; they make a little noise, an inconsistent noise which doesn't bother me. In order to exist, they must consort with others.

I am alone, entirely alone. I never speak to anyone, never; I receive nothing, I give nothing.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker), The Self-Taught Man

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 14

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, *Nausea*'s narrator and protagonist, Roquentin, sits in the Café Mably and watches the crowds of working-class people talk to one another as he contemplates his own loneliness. Here, Roquentin exhibits behavior that he repeats frequently throughout the novel: he observes the rhythms of society from the outside. Part of his isolation seems to come from his socioeconomic class. After all, Roquentin frequents the Café Mably and other restaurants for more or less every meal he eats, and if the Café is "luxurious," then he must have quite a bit of money compared to the people who can only visit now and then as a treat. Without traditional employment, Roquentin doesn't have an easily available companion to eat with. In fact, the

Chapter 7: Friday Quotes

☞ I lean all my weight on the porcelain ledge, I draw my face closer until it touches the mirror. The eyes, nose and mouth disappear: nothing human is left. Brown wrinkles show on each side of the feverish swelled lips, crevices, mole holes. A silky white down covers the great slopes of the cheeks, two hairs protrude from the nostrils: it is a geological embossed map. And, in spite of everything, this lunar world is familiar to me.

I cannot say I recognize the details. But the whole thing gives me an impression of something seen before which stupefies me.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 17

Explanation and Analysis

In this quotation, Roquentin stares at his own face in the mirror as the bright sun illuminates his features. Beset by "Nausea," the term he has coined to describe his growing sense of existential dread, he can remember that his face is a familiar sight, but he has trouble linking what he sees to the concept of his face. As it often does when Roquentin is struggling with Nausea, Sartre's writing takes on an impressionistic style. Roquentin literalizes this as he enlarges the individual features of his face by pressing it against the mirror, blurring his perception of the whole. As he looks at himself, he starts to see only a "geological embossed map," a visual object that requires a key to decipher, which he currently does not have.

Roquentin's inability to recognize his face suggests that he is out of touch with his own identity, a problem that continues to grow throughout the novel as Roquentin grapples with his reasons for being alive. To reflect this

depersonalization, Roquentin doesn't think of his features in the mirror as "his," but rather as "the" eyes, lips, cheeks, and so on.

Chapter 8: 5.30 Quotes

☹☹ What has just happened is that the Nausea has disappeared. When the voice was heard in the silence, I felt my body harden and the Nausea vanish. Suddenly: it was almost unbearable to become so hard, so brilliant. At the same time the music was drawn out, dilated, swelled like a waterspout. It filled the room with its metallic transparency, crushing our miserable time against the walls. I am *in* the music. Globes of fire turn in the mirrors; encircled by rings of smoke, veiling and unveiling the hard smile of light. My glass of beer has shrunk, it seems heaped up on the table, it looks dense and indispensable. I want to pick it up and feel the weight of it, I stretch out my hand . . . God! That is what has changed, my gestures. This movement of my arm has developed like a majestic theme, it has glided along the song of the Negress; I seemed to be dancing.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 22

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Roquentin listens to his favorite jazz record, "Some of these days," in the *Rendezvous des Cheminots*. As soon as the music starts to play, the near seasickness caused by Roquentin's Nausea starts to abate. Here, the singer on the record has just begun the chorus of the song, and Roquentin abruptly feels much, much better. What he experiences isn't just a lessening or disappearance of the Nausea—he actually seems to feel completely euphoric, even purposeful, in a way that he generally isn't when the record is not playing. Roquentin describes his clarity in terms of "hardness," calling his newfound mental state "brilliant" and "metallic" like precious ore in contrast to the roiling, uncertain softness that comes with the Nausea. Even his glass of beer, which had previously assaulted him with its existence, now seems "dense" and solid to him instead of flimsy and unrecognizable. Sartre's diction heightens the impression that music seems to be a lifeline to solid ground for Roquentin. Roquentin also notes his increased awareness of time as the music plays, experiencing time subjectively as infinite even as the music is by nature ephemeral.

Chapter 11: Friday, 3.00 p.m. Quotes

☹☹ I have never had adventures. Things have happened to me, events, incidents, anything you like. But no adventures. It isn't a question of words; I am beginning to understand. There is something to which I clung more than all the rest — without completely realizing it. [...] It was ... I had imagined that at certain times my life could take on a rare and precious quality. There was no need for extraordinary circumstances: all I asked for was a little precision. There is nothing brilliant about my life now: but from time to time, for example, when they play music in the cafes, I look back and tell myself : in old days, in London, Meknes, Tokyo, I have known great moments, I have had adventures. Now I am deprived of this. I have suddenly learned, without any apparent reason, that I have been lying to myself for ten years. And naturally, everything they tell about in books can happen in real life, but not in the same way. It is to this way of happening that I clung so tightly.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker), The Self-Taught Man, Anny

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 37

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Roquentin realizes that he's never had a true adventure before after showing the Self-Taught Man photos from his travels. The Self-Taught Man expressed envy and admiration for the education that Roquentin has received by travelling and experiencing the world in person, while the Self-Taught Man does all of his own learning from books. After the Self-Taught Man asks Roquentin about the adventures he's had, Roquentin starts to dissect the word in his mind. He realizes that an adventure is something that one must have, rather than the other way around, and that as he's been floating aimlessly and passively through his own life, he can't say that he's truly had an adventure. Roquentin has believed that certain special moments—comparable to the "perfect moments" and "privileged situations" that Anny later discusses—contain the potential for adventure. Now, however, he feels cut off from that old belief. Roquentin often compares himself to the hero of a novel and comes up short. Here, he laments that adventures don't happen the way they do in books. Of course, the irony is that Roquentin unwittingly *is* the hero of a novel: *Nausea*.

Chapter 13: Sunday Quotes

☹☹ It was Sunday; massed between the balustrade and the gates of residents' chalets, the crowd dispersed slowly... [...] these people were neither sad nor gay: they were at rest. Their wide-open, staring eyes passively reflected sea and sky. [...] I didn't know what to do with my hard, vigorous body in the midst of this tragic, relaxed crowd. [...] The light grows softer. At this uncertain hour one felt evening drawing in. Sunday was already past. [...] For a moment I wondered if I were not going to love humanity. But, after all, it was their Sunday, not mine.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 52-3

Explanation and Analysis

In this chapter, Roquentin takes to the streets and joins the crowds of working-class people walking the streets on a Sunday, the one day of the week that most of the working world has off. Roquentin walks the city over the course of the entire day, and his journal entry takes on a lyrical, jazzy quality as he repeats and rephrases the line, "It was Sunday." His attention to the day of the week heightens the passage's portrayal of time as a subjective force. The day seems to stretch on forever, perhaps because Roquentin is so conscious of how different the Sunday is compared to the other days of the week.

Crucially, Roquentin's experience of the Sunday is also entirely different from the working class's experience of the Sunday, and he's very aware of this fact. For Roquentin, who only chips away at his historical research in bits and pieces for something to do, days blend together without order or significance. He doesn't keep a schedule, and he's free of most obligations that constrain people with less money: working hours, families, and so on. Thus, the people around him are soaking up every moment of their one day off, languid and slow, while he's "hard" and "vigorous," unable to fully appreciate the day for what it is. The quotation reinforces Roquentin's profound loneliness and feelings of separation from all of humanity.

☹☹ I am alone, most of the people have gone back home, they are reading the evening paper, listening to the radio. Sunday has left them with a taste of ashes and their thoughts are already turning towards Monday. But for me there is neither Monday nor Sunday: there are days which pass in disorder, and then, sudden lightning like this one.

Nothing has changed and yet everything is different. I can't describe it; it's like the Nausea and yet it's just the opposite: at last an adventure happens to me and when I question myself I see that it happens that I am myself and that I am here; I am the one who splits the night, I am as happy as the hero of a novel.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 54

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Roquentin continues to walk the streets as Sunday begins to draw to a close. Again, he feels alienated from those around him, since his life and schedule are so different. Roquentin can only imagine what the working-class people are doing now—"reading the evening paper, listening to the radio"—because he has no access to their actual homes and lives outside of his observations of them in public spaces. Still, as he has watched and participated in the Sunday to the best of his ability, he has begun to feel like the day is significant for him, too: "sudden lightning."

Since Roquentin ultimately comes to define adventure as moments when he is perfectly aware of the irreversibility of time, it seems like his vicarious experience of the fleeting specialness of a Sunday has given him this sense of adventure that he's been craving. Awareness of the fact that the day is ending and will inevitably give over into Monday cheers him up and inspires him to pursue the call to adventure. As he follows it, he feels aware of his existence. This is a hallmark of Roquentin's Nausea, but as he notes in this passage, his reaction to his own existence is opposite to what it usually is. He feels purposeful as he pursues adventure, and so existence is not as painful and pointless as he usually finds it.

Chapter 16: 11.00 p.m. Quotes

☛ I dined at the *Rendezvous des Cheminots*. The patronne was there and I had to kiss her, but it was mainly out of politeness. [...] I played distractedly with her sex under the cover; then my arm went to sleep. [...] I let my arm run along the woman's thigh, and suddenly saw a small garden with low, wide trees on which immense hairy leaves were hanging. Ants were running everywhere, centipedes and ringworm. There were even more horrible animals: their bodies were made from a slice of toast, the kind you put under roast pigeons; they walked sideways with legs like a crab. The larger leaves were black with beasts. Behind the cactus and the Barbary fig trees, the Velleda of the public park pointed a finger at her sex. "This park smells of vomit," I shouted.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker), Françoise

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 59

Explanation and Analysis

In this quotation, Roquentin goes to the *Rendezvous des Cheminots* and starts to have sex with the patronne, Françoise, for lack of anything better to do. Roquentin has previously described Françoise as someone who has sex with many men out of compulsion, and with whom he's cordial but utterly detached, even businesslike. Roquentin has apparently been fine with this situation up until now, but in this passage, he begins to feel utterly disgusted by Françoise.

It's not entirely clear whether Roquentin's disgust stems from some aspect of Françoise's body or personality, or whether it's a reaction to the nature of their relationship itself. Theirs is an arrangement that just exists, totally devoid of significance or essence, and bare existence without meaning frequently disgusts Roquentin. However, the language in this passage also hints that he might be disturbed by Françoise's pubic hair, which he seems to visualize as a thick, dense garden. The garden in his mind is full of horrible creatures, as if infested. Roquentin's focus on insects and creatures that scuttle like crabs particularly calls to mind a possible paranoia about sexually transmitted diseases such as pubic lice, which could indicate his subconscious disgust with Françoise's promiscuity. Throughout all of this lyrical, figurative prose, it's not entirely clear what's happening on the literal level. Is Roquentin asleep and dreaming, or awake and

hallucinating? Does he have sex with Françoise, or does the encounter stop with his hand on her thigh? Roquentin doesn't care to clarify, and as his narration is the reader's only source of information, the matter remains ambiguous.

Chapter 17: Shrove Tuesday Quotes

☛ Soft glow: people are in their houses, they have undoubtedly turned on the lights too. They read, they watch the sky from their window. For them it means something different. They have aged differently. They live in the midst of legacies, gifts, each piece of furniture holds a memory. Clocks, medallions, portraits, shells, paperweights, screens, shawls. They have closets full of bottles, stuffs, old clothes, newspapers; they have kept everything. The past is a landlord's luxury.

Where shall I keep mine? You don't put your past in your pocket; you have to have a house. I have only my body: a man entirely alone, with his lonely body, cannot indulge in memories; they pass through him. I shouldn't complain: all I wanted was to be free.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker), Achilles

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 65

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Roquentin sits in the Café Mably in early morning, just after his encounter with Achilles. As he sits in the café alone, he imagines what the rest of the city must be doing at this hour. Again, his thoughts turn to the relativity of time, claiming that the people he thinks of have "aged differently."

Roquentin has already established that the working class lives life on a different schedule than Roquentin himself does, but now he elaborates on how companionship changes the human experience of time. People who are surrounded by other people, especially families and parents, have connections to the past, which makes the present more significant. Roquentin appears a bit envious of this concrete evidence of time's passage, which takes up space and is thus a "landlord's luxury" (since it requires land, or a home, to store). His meaning is largely figurative, however: Roquentin is less concerned with physical possessions than with the deep, meaningful human relationships that they represent in this quotation. The passage highlights the fact that Roquentin has no visible ties to almost anybody. He never mentions his parents or any family at all, so he has no

legacy to continue. He doesn't have a partner or children, so he has no house to fill, literal or otherwise. His freedom comes at a high cost: loneliness and insignificance.

Chapter 20: Friday Quotes

☞ Fog had filled the room: not the real fog, that had gone a long time ago—but the other, the one the streets were still full of, which came out of the walls and pavements. The inconsistency of inanimate objects! [...]

I held the book I was reading tightly in my hands: but the most violent sensations went dead. Nothing seemed true; I felt surrounded by cardboard scenery which could quickly be removed. The world was waiting, holding its breath, making itself small—it was waiting for its convulsion, its Nausea, just like M. Achille the other day.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 76-77

Explanation and Analysis

In this quotation, Roquentin sits in the Bouville library's reading room and begins to spiral into worsening Nausea and derealization. When he woke up this morning, the streets were full of a dense fog, and these conditions have been affecting almost everyone Roquentin has seen so far. The fog, obscuring the reality of things and making the world blurry, soft, and unclear, represents Roquentin's poor mental state. Indeed, as Roquentin sits indoors in this passage, the fog has become entirely mental. It's important to clarify that the fog isn't Nausea itself, which exposes the truth of existence underneath the veneer of constructed essence. Rather, the fog is Roquentin's reaction to the Nausea. He has no idea how to interpret the feelings he has been having, and they fill him with confusion and uncertainty. As a result, everything around him looks fake and unreliable, like scenery in a play. More and more, Roquentin starts to think of the Nausea as something that will reach the other inhabitants of Bouville sooner or later. In this "convulsion," when the Nausea catches up to them, they'll realize that the lives they thought they were living in accordance with duty and right are actually completely devoid of meaning.

☞ I suddenly understood: the cloak! I wanted to stop it. It would have been enough to cough or open the gate. But in my turn I was fascinated by the little girl's face. Her features were drawn with fear and her heart must have been beating horribly; yet I could also read something powerful and wicked on that rat-like face. It was not curiosity but rather a sort of assured expectation. I felt impotent: I was outside, on the edge of the park, on the edge of their little drama: but they were riveted one to the other by the obscure power of their desires, they made a pair together.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker), The Self-Taught Man

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 79

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Roquentin witnesses a man in a cloak, whom he has passed sitting in the public park several times throughout the day, and a little girl. At first, he isn't sure what to make of the man's apparent interest in the girl, but as he watches, he realizes what the man intends to do. Roquentin doesn't explicitly state it, but it seems likely that the man is partially or completely nude under the cloak and that he intends to flash the little girl for his own sexual gratification. Characteristically, Roquentin considers intervention, but he defaults to passive observation instead.

Rather perversely, Roquentin gets the feeling that he is powerless to divert the incident and that the little girl who would be the victim of the crime holds the power in the scenario. His description of the scene makes the man in the cape and the little girl sound more like a flirtatious couple, "a pair," than a criminal and his victim. Roquentin's subtle sympathy with the man in the cape and condemnation of the "wicked" and "rat-like" little girl flips the expected power dynamic on its head. It also foreshadows the encounter between the Self-Taught Man and the boy that he fondles at the library toward the end of the novel.

Chapter 22: Afternoon Quotes

☞ Then I realized what separated us: what I thought about him could not reach him; it was psychology, the kind they write about in books. But his judgment went through me like a sword and questioned my very right to exist. And it was true, I had always realized it; I hadn't the right to exist. I had appeared by chance, I existed like a stone, a plant or a microbe. [...]

But for this handsome, faultless man, now dead, for Jean Pacôme, son of the Pacôme of the Défence Nationale, it had been an entirely different matter: the beating of his heart and the mute rumblings of his organs, in his case, assumed the form of rights to be instantly obeyed. For sixty years, without a halt, he had used his right to live. [...] He had always done his duty...

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 84

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Roquentin has paid a visit to the Bouville museum to look at a portrait of Olivier Blévine that he remembers looking wrong in a way he can't explain. When he reaches the room full of portraits of important men and women, he realizes that his life has been utterly different from theirs, and he feels that the eyes of the paintings are judging him. Although Roquentin will later attack the portrait subjects' "right" to existence, too, they have a claim to that right that he does not. The portrait subjects have generally all done something or other for society as a whole: married, had children, fought in wars, cured injuries, made discoveries, and so on. Roquentin, who has spent his life so far in pursuit of momentary impulses and self-serving pleasures such as travelling for personal enrichment, cannot say the same. As Roquentin looks at the portrait of Blévine, he becomes conscious of this fact. For the first time, Roquentin realizes that the unpleasantness of the Nausea comes from his awareness of the *pointlessness* of his existence, not just from the awareness of existence itself.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 98

Explanation and Analysis

This passage takes place just after Roquentin has finally given up on writing his history of the Marquis de Rollebon. For the three years or so that he has spent trying to write his book, he has allowed the Marquis's life and existence to overtake his own. Now, having relinquished the Marquis for good, he feels fully aware of his own existence. For the first time, he thinks of the Nausea as an extension of himself, writing that he himself is "the Thing" that waits for him in the contraction of Nausea. He writes about the sensation with sparse clarity, in contrast to his earlier overwrought descriptions of his experience: "I exist." The two-word phrase boils down Nausea to its absolute essentials: it's the internal conviction of one's existence, completely removed from the baggage of essence. Roquentin describes this as a sort of freedom, existence "liberated" from essence, and for the moment, he's happy with the sensation. Later, though, his consciousness of his existence is not enough to make him happy. As the novel continues, Roquentin has to come to terms with what being liberated from a meaningful life really means—but this quotation represents a big stride in his understanding of his Nausea.

☞ Little Lucienne was raped. Strangled. Her body still exists, her flesh bleeding. *She* no longer exists. [...] I am. I am. I exist, I think, therefore I am; I am because I think, why do I think? I don't want to think any more, I am because I think that I don't want to be, I think that I... because... ugh! I flee. The criminal has fled, the violated body. She felt this other flesh pushing into her own. I... there I... Raped. A soft, criminal desire to rape catches me from behind, gently behind the ears, the ears race behind me, the red hair, it is red on my head, the wet grass, red grass, is it still I? Hold the paper, existence against existence, things exist one against the other.

Chapter 23: Monday Quotes

☞ The thing which was waiting was on the alert, it has pounced on me, it flows through me, I am filled with it. It's nothing: I am the Thing. Existence, liberated, detached, floods over me: I exist.

I exist. It's sweet, so sweet, so slow. And light: you'd think it floated all by itself. It stirs. It brushes by me; melts and vanishes.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 100-101

Explanation and Analysis

This passage continues Roquentin's clear revelation of his

own existence following his refusal to continue working on his book about the Marquis de Rollebon. Sure enough, his consciousness of his own self in the phrase “I exist” has become sour and oppressive, and he already has ceased to think of existence as a kind of freedom. Instead, he begins to think of it as a kind of “rape,” which he both enacts and endures. Awareness of existence gives way to stream-of-consciousness narration as Roquentin grows increasingly uncomfortable with his own mind, and he starts to blend pieces from a news item about a little girl named Lucienne who was raped on the street into Roquentin’s own self-image. He pictures himself fleeing from the fact of his own existence in the same way that the rapist fled Lucienne’s body, which continued to exist even after her soul left it. Confused as he is about his own identity, the consciousness of the rapist starts to fuse with his own.

☛ He runs, the heart, the heart beats, it’s a holiday, the heart exists, the legs exist, the breath exists, they exist running, breathing, beating, all soft, all gently breathless, leaving me breathless, he says he’s breathless; existence takes my thoughts from behind and gently expands them *from behind*; someone takes me from behind, they force me to think from behind, therefore to be something, behind me, breathing in light bubbles of existence, he is a bubble of fog and desire, he is pale as death in the glass, Rollebon is dead, Antoine Roquentin is not dead, I’m fainting: he says he would like to faint, he runs, he runs like a ferret, “from behind” from behind *from behind*, little Lucienne assaulted from behind, violated by existence from behind, he begs for mercy, he is ashamed of begging for mercy, pity, help, help therefore I exist...

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 102

Explanation and Analysis

This passage continues Roquentin’s stream-of-consciousness narration following his revelation of his own existence. The quotation above is all one remarkably long sentence, reflecting the real rapidity of Roquentin’s thoughts as he struggles to understand what he’s going through. It stands in marked contrast to the short line that began Roquentin’s musings in the first place: “I exist.”

This passage is the more complicated version of “I exist”—now Roquentin exists but is horrified by his own existence to the extent of comparing himself to a rape victim. Roquentin identifies alternately with the rapist and

raped from the news story because he feels like a criminal for existing in the world without any good reason, but he also never asked to exist in the first place. He thinks of his existence, then, as a crime that he unwillingly commits against the world. Roquentin’s stress and fragmentation manifests in his use of the third person, another distinct departure from the “I exist” theme.

Chapter 25: Wednesday Quotes

☛ “Perhaps you are a misanthrope?”

I know what this fallacious effort at conciliation hides. He asks little from me: simply to accept a label. But it is a trap: if I consent, the Self-Taught Man wins, I am immediately turned round, reconstituted, overtaken, for humanism takes possession and melts all human attitudes into one. [...] He has digested anti-intellectualism, Manicheism, mysticism, pessimism, anarchy and egotism: they are nothing more than stages, unfinished thoughts which find their justification only in him. Misanthropy also has its place in the concert: it is only a dissonance necessary to the harmony of the whole. The misanthrope is a man: therefore the humanist must be misanthropic to a certain extent.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin, The Self-Taught Man (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 118

Explanation and Analysis

In this scene, the Self-Taught Man poses Roquentin a question as the two of them share an awkward meal at a restaurant. After Roquentin has an outburst in which he reveals that he has begun to think of life as devoid of meaning, the Self-Taught Man divulges that he is a humanist. He tells Roquentin about his past, explaining that he fought in World War I and was taken prisoner in a German camp for two years. There, in the crowded camp full of men, he learned how to love humanity, and he later became a dedicated humanist and Socialist. To Roquentin, this is in keeping with the Self-Taught Man’s character as someone who passionately seeks all his knowledge from books. Roquentin, who is not a devotee of humanism, feels that the Self-Taught Man has been led astray by the humanist scholars he’s read.

Now, as the Self-Taught Man asks Roquentin to accept a label, Roquentin describes his problem with humanist

philosophy in his journal. Basically, he perceives it as a system that depends on treating individual people as essences—that is, as abstract concepts that merely represent humanity rather than dealing with its existence head-on. In this way, Sartre stages a criticism of humanism using the vocabulary he has built up to introduce the Existentialism he puts forth in *Nausea*.

☛ I don't need to turn around to know they are watching me through the windows: they are watching my back with surprise and disgust; they thought I was like them, that I was a man, and I deceived them. I suddenly lost the appearance of a man and they saw a crab running backwards out of this human room. Now the unmasked intruder has fled: the show goes on.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 124

Explanation and Analysis

In this quotation, Roquentin flees the restaurant after his meal with the Self-Taught Man turns unpleasant. After the Self-Taught Man urges him to accept a label that he can fold under the umbrella of humanism and then tries to insist that Roquentin loves humanity even if he doesn't know it, Roquentin feels a bout of the Nausea come on, and he leaves the restaurant in a conspicuous hurry. As he leaves, he is uncomfortably aware again of his distance and alienation from the crowd he was dining among. Roquentin frequently feels alienated in this way, but in this instance, everyone in the restaurant is actually watching him, instead of it being the other way around. For once, Roquentin's paranoia about being on the outside of society seems fully justified. Roquentin's comparison of himself to a crab evokes a sense of shame and lowness, as the crab scuttles quickly away from danger. However, it also recalls his childhood memory of the man in the garden who looked at his own foot as if it were a crustacean—that is, as if the foot were something totally unfamiliar to him. Roquentin feared becoming ridiculed and divorced from reality like that man, and now he's fulfilled that fear.

Chapter 26: 6.00 p.m. Quotes

☛ The trees floated. Gushing towards the sky? Or rather a collapse; at any instant I expected to see the tree-trunks shrivel like weary wands, crumple up, fall on the ground in a soft, folded, black heap. *They did not want to exist*, only they could not help themselves [...] Tired and old, they kept on existing, against the grain, simply because they were too weak to die, because death could only come to them from the outside: strains of music alone can proudly carry their own death within themselves like an internal necessity: only they don't exist. Every existing thing is born without reason, prolongs itself out of weakness and dies by chance.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 133

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Roquentin stumbles into the public garden where the man in the cape tried to flash the little girl. Roquentin arrives at the garden after his meal with the Self-Taught Man turned ugly over a disagreement about humanism. He took public transport to get here, and as he watched his hand and the seats on the train, his sense of reality started to give way to his awareness of existence as the Nausea set in. In the garden, Roquentin has a revelation of existence that echoes his realization after putting aside the Marquis de Rollebon. He finally feels like he understands the Nausea completely. As he looks around at the scenery within the garden, he contemplates the existence of the trees, which like him, did not ask to exist. In the last line of this quotation, Roquentin finally puts a fine point on something that has been troubling him: in a world where life and death are utterly unplanned and largely insignificant, what reason is there to keep living? Roquentin does note music as an exception to this, which foreshadows the conclusion he reaches in the last pages of the novel.

Chapter 31: Tuesday, in Bouville Quotes

☛ What if something were to happen? What if something suddenly started throbbing? Then they would notice it was there and they'd think their hearts were going to burst. Then what good would their dykes, bulwarks, power houses, furnaces and pile drivers be to them? It can happen any time, perhaps right now: the omens are present. For example, the father of a family might go out for a walk, and, across the street, he'll see something like a red rag, blown towards him by the wind. And when the rag has gotten close to him he'll see that it is a side of rotten meat, grimy with dust, dragging itself along by crawling, skipping, a piece of writhing flesh rolling in the gutter, spasmodically shooting out spurts of blood. [...] Then you will see other people, suddenly plunged into solitude.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker), Anny

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 159

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Roquentin stands at the top of a hill overlooking Bouville and mourns. He has just returned from his trip to see Anny in Paris, which did not go as he hoped: Anny refused to reenter into a relationship with him, instead leaving to travel as a kept woman to wealthy men. Roquentin now is out of ideas for things to spend his life pursuing, and he worries that his life will be meaningless forever. In this mood, he looks down at the Bouville houses and wonders when everyone else will feel as terrified and aimless as he does. This attitude is a slight departure from his musings at the portrait gallery, where he looked at the portraits of people who lived their lives confidently with some envy. Now, he occupies higher ground, literally and figuratively. Roquentin is sure that underneath the confident lives that other people lead, the same crisis of a meaningless existence lies in wait. And everyone else experiences it the way he does, the city will have something like a psychological apocalypse. He presents twisted images of things that are not as they seem, representing the “wrong”-ness that lies underneath the thin veneer of God’s significance.

Chapter 32: Wednesday: My last day in Bouville Quotes

☛ [The Self-Taught Man] must be walking at random, filled with shame and horror—this poor humanist whom men don’t want. To tell the truth, I was hardly surprised when the thing happened: for a long time I had thought that his soft, timid face would bring scandal on itself. He was so little guilty: his humble, contemplative love for young boys is hardly sensuality—rather a form of humanity. But one day he had to find himself alone. Like M. Achille, like me: he is one of my race, he has good will. Now he has entered into solitude—forever.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker), The Self-Taught Man, The Corsican Guard

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 160

Explanation and Analysis

This passage opens Chapter 32, in which Roquentin recounts a catastrophic incident at the reading room. The Self-Taught Man, whom Roquentin has previously noticed looking at students and having troubles with the Corsican guard, succumbs to his urges and molests a young student underneath a table and in clear sight of witnesses. The Corsican guard attacks him and drives him out of the library, and he vanishes into the streets despite Roquentin’s intervention and sympathy on his behalf.

In fact, Roquentin seems to have more kinship with the Self-Taught Man in this passage than ever before. What once read as mild condescension gives way to pity and identification as he thinks of the Self-Taught Man as “one of [his] race”: an alienated, lonely person. Roquentin considers the Self-Taught Man’s pedophilia and likely homosexuality as factors that simply make him misunderstood, an outsider who can’t remain in society’s good graces (though readers should note that such a view consciously ignores the harm that the Self-Taught man’s predatory actions inflict on the young student). This is a feeling that is familiar to Roquentin. The revelation of the Self-Taught Man’s problems also casts his humanist philosophy in a sick, ironic light, as Roquentin notes. Suddenly, his “love of men” doesn’t seem as virtuous as it once did, and his overzealous love of children makes him an enemy to men forever.

Chapter 33: One hour later Quotes

☝ Couldn't I try... Naturally, it wouldn't be a question of a tune... But couldn't I, in another medium?... It would have to be a book; I don't know how to do anything else. But not a history book: history talks about what has existed—an existent can never justify the existence of another existent. My error, I wanted to resuscitate the Marquis de Rollebon. Another type of book. I don't quite know which kind—but you would have to guess, behind the printed words, behind the pages, at something which would not exist, which would be above existence. A story, for example, something that could never happen, an adventure. It would have to be beautiful and hard as steel and make people ashamed of their existence.

Related Characters: Antoine Roquentin (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 178

Explanation and Analysis

This passage is one of the last in the novel. In it, Roquentin finally settles on the solution that he has been seeking throughout *Nausea*: he decides to write a novel of his own. He differentiates it from the historical research on the

Marquis de Rollebon to which he has dedicated the last three years of his life, claiming that a novel would free itself of the history's obligation to existing things and allow Roquentin to do something pure and essential.

This conclusion also represents the end of Roquentin's struggle to reconcile his mild disdain for literature with his predisposition toward imagination. Throughout his diary, he has here and there scolded himself for becoming too literary in his description of the events of his life. As he wrote his book on the Marquis, he frequently found himself preferring to think of his own image of the Marquis instead of sorting out the facts of his existence. In this way, Roquentin's decision to write a novel also marks the end of a fight he's been having with himself: he consents to imagine. It's hard to say for sure if Roquentin is likely to succeed in this new endeavor or give it up like he has everything else he's tried. Considering the Editors' Note at the beginning of *Nausea*, however, it looks like Roquentin becomes someone worthy of study in one way or another. And on a meta level, of course, Roquentin is Sartre's fictional creation and therefore does not exist in reality. Roquentin has thus already achieved his desire to cast off the burden of existence.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1: EDITORS' NOTE

A brief note explains that the text of *Nausea* is transcribed verbatim from the files of Antoine Roquentin. It goes on to estimate that the undated pages at the beginning of the novel were written around January of 1932. Antoine Roquentin had moved to the town of Bouville to complete his research after a period of travel. The note is signed, "The Editors."

The Editors' Note presents Roquentin's journal with some background context, framing Roquentin (a fictional creation of Sartre's) as not only the narrator of *Nausea*, but also as its author. The fact the editors have published Roquentin's journal suggests that Roquentin must have achieved some kind of importance or notoriety after *Nausea*'s events.



CHAPTER 2: UNDATED PAGES

Worried that he has undergone a "change" (which he doesn't directly describe), Roquentin considers journaling. He muses that if he keeps a detailed diary describing the objects and people around him, he can tell once and for all whether he has changed. Roquentin briefly details the events of Saturday and the day before yesterday. On Saturday, he picked up a stone to throw into the sea, but became abruptly disgusted by it, dropped it, and left. A group of children playing nearby laughed at his erratic behavior. Roquentin still doesn't know what about the sea or the stone disgusted him. He doesn't record exactly what happened the day before yesterday—only that he felt an inexplicable fear. Roquentin reassures himself that his confusing feelings toward objects do not make him insane, although he isn't certain of this.

Roquentin decides to document his perceptions of the world around him, scrutinizing his own mind in the process. He finds that he has begun to see mundane things very differently. Even something as simple as a stone now inspires feelings of fear and disgust, and at this point in the story, Roquentin can't pinpoint why that is. Roquentin's notice of the crowd of children mocking him highlights his loneliness and paranoia. Isolated as he already is, a single man in a big city, he is afraid of people thinking that he's insane. Even in his private journal, he finds himself unable to confront the idea.



Sometime later, Roquentin feels much better. He watches the street traffic outside his window and describes it in detail, feeling comfortable in his observation of the world. Hearing the footsteps of a familiar stranger ascending the stairs of his hotel, Roquentin feels completely reassured by the routine of the night. He decides that he is cured of whatever problem he was experiencing and prepares for bed. Roquentin plans to abandon his diary. The entry trails off mid-sentence as he ponders what would make a journal interesting.

Roquentin is experiencing bursts of a completely unfamiliar mental state, so when the world's rhythms are recognizable to him, he's relieved. For all that Roquentin has only taken up journaling to document his concerns, observation seems to be natural for him. His lack of active participation in society makes him attentive to the details of his surroundings.



CHAPTER 3: MONDAY, 29 JANUARY, 1932

Roquentin is now convinced that something is wrong with him, after all. He recounts some incidents he's experienced lately. For instance, he recently felt an unfamiliar object with "a sort of personality" in his hand as he entered a room, only to realize it was a doorknob. He also failed to recognize the face of the Self-Taught Man, whom he's known for two years. And he was also disgusted by the Self-Taught Man's hand, which Roquentin here compares to a worm. Reflecting on these incidents, Roquentin wonders whether it's himself or the world around him that has changed.

The strange incidents bothering Roquentin seem to be connected by his newfound inability to recognize commonplace objects and people. The pattern indicates that his underlying problem must be related to a breakdown of the part of his consciousness that connects objects to their names. In other words, Roquentin is losing his ability to interact with the world through the filter of essence and is instead being assaulted by the existence of things. The latter is the "sort of personality" that he tries to describe in the doorknob.



In a new section, Roquentin concludes that he is the one who is not the same as he was. He supposes that throughout his life, changes have crept up on him and taken him by surprise once they've accumulated so much that he can't ignore them anymore. Roquentin remembers when he first started travelling the world with Mercier, an archaeologist. It was Roquentin's passionate dream to travel, but after six years of seeing the world, he suddenly "woke up" and felt disgusted by his surroundings. Roquentin particularly remembers the smell of perfume wafting from Mercier's beard as he told Mercier that he wanted to return to France. Breaking from his reminiscence, Roquentin wonders whether he is on the brink of a drastic change in his life. He worries that something will awaken inside of him and take control of his actions.

Although Roquentin has only recently begun to feel disgust and fear when touching and regarding objects, this section clarifies that he has felt disgusted with his own life for quite a bit longer. Just as Roquentin became disenchanted with travel and felt overwhelmed by the scent of Mercier's beard, so now does he grow unhappy with his life in Bouville and overwhelmed by his other senses. In the midst of all his confusion, Roquentin's passivity is remarkable. Accustomed to thinking of his life as something that simply happens to him, he looks at these new changes in much the same way. Although he's afraid, he seems resigned to sitting back and documenting his mental state as it shifts.



CHAPTER 4: TUESDAY, 30 JANUARY

Roquentin reports that "nothing new" has happened since his last entry. As he writes, he eats at the Café Mably, a place he frequents. The owner of the café, Monsieur Fasquelle, talks to customers when the building is full but takes naps when business is slow. Looking around at the other customers chatting with one another, Roquentin reflects on how alone he is. He sometimes has sex with Françoise, a woman who runs the nearby Rendezvous des Cheminots, but their conversations are impersonal and businesslike. Roquentin has even mostly forgotten his ex-lover, Anny. Most of his thoughts are vague and fleeting.

Here and throughout Nausea, Roquentin is frequently in or adjacent to groups of people without really being a part of them. Even in a room full of people, Roquentin seems to have nobody to talk to. The relationships he does have, such as his arrangement with Françoise, are superficial and lacking in significance. Seemingly without realizing what he has done, Roquentin has isolated himself.



Roquentin muses that people who live alone forget how to talk to others and put their experiences into coherent words. At the same time, however, he suggests that solitary people can be attentive to everything without worrying about how their observations will sound to other people. As an example, Roquentin recalls seeing a woman in blue bump into a Black person in a raincoat under a streetlight. He remembers the colors of their clothes and the light and the expressions on their faces in detail. The scene inspired a powerful emotion in Roquentin, but it soon faded away into nothingness. He states that a person must be lonely to feel this emotion. Roquentin has felt it for some time, but he has always believed that he could ease it by seeking out others' company again. Now, however, he thinks that it's too late.

Although Roquentin tends to observe couples with mild condescension, here he seems to feel genuine longing when he recalls the scene under the streetlight. His memory of the man and woman meeting is vivid and evocative. Roquentin's careful attention to detail and the emotion that he feels in recalling it make the scene a picturesque and striking one, the sort of incidence that Anny later calls a "perfect moment." Seeing a man and woman together makes Roquentin feel aware of his loneliness as an observer of life rather than a participant in it.



Roquentin now has trouble looking directly at objects. He believes that beneath their external characteristics, the objects contain something else, but he can't articulate what it is. Roquentin remembers a man with a neck tumor that he used to see while playing with his friends as a child. The man would wear a boot on one foot and a slipper on the other, and he would periodically stare at his own outstretched foot in fear. Roquentin and his friends were terrified of the man's visible loneliness and derealization. Roquentin wishes that he could reunite with Anny and tell someone his fears.

Roquentin's recollection of the man with the neck tumor mirrors his own earlier behavior. The crowd of children that watched him drop the stone by the sea recalls Roquentin's own pack of childhood friends. Now, Roquentin is starting to understand what that man, whose perceptible instability once frightened Roquentin, might have felt like.



Roquentin admits that he started his entry with a lie: something did happen to him. He confesses that he saw a piece of paper lying on the ground and wanted to pick it up, but he found himself unable to. Roquentin usually likes to pick things up from the ground and touch them, but this time, he tries and fails to make himself do it. He states that he has lost his freedom and is no longer able to do what he wants. Roquentin describes the feeling that he gets when interacting with objects now: instead of touching them, they seem to touch him. He calls the sensation "a sort of nausea in the hands."

Here, Roquentin finally gives a name to the strange feeling that's been plaguing him: Nausea. His passivity comes through even in how he thinks about this sensation—it's something that touches him while he's helpless to avoid it. Beyond that, it becomes clear in this section how unreliable and subjective Roquentin's narration is. He admits to lying and omitting in his journal entries, which calls the "truth" of all of Nausea into question. Moreover, though, it highlights the individuality and subjectivity of all human experience, which is one aspect of the Nausea that Roquentin must come to terms with.



CHAPTER 5: THURSDAY MORNING IN THE LIBRARY

Roquentin records a conversation he overheard between Lucie—a charwoman, or cleaning lady—and the landlady of the hotel. Lucie vented to the landlady about her handsome young husband, who Roquentin implies might have married the middle-aged Lucie for her money. Lucie told the landlady that she would prefer for her husband to have sex with other women, and that she needed to "take the upper hand." Roquentin thinks that Lucie is trapped in her own suffering, singing and humming to stop herself from reflecting on her own sadness, and wonders if she wishes for freedom from her pain.

Roquentin seems to sense something of a kindred spirit in Lucie, but there are marked differences in their situations. Lucie has a traditional job and a partner, but they only seem to cause her sorrow. Roquentin, on the other hand, lacks both of those things and is plagued by apathy and numbness more than sadness. Still, Roquentin speculates that they both feel helpless, stuck in their ways with no escape.



CHAPTER 6: THURSDAY AFTERNOON

Roquentin re-reads the paragraph that first introduced him to the Marquis de Rollebon. The passage summarizes Rollebon's success with women and involvement in political intrigue, culminating in his sudden imprisonment and eventual death. As he reads, Roquentin reflects on how much his interest in the Marquis has waned. He realizes that he's no longer motivated to write his book because of the Marquis. Instead, he's motivated by the act of writing itself. Roquentin wonders whether Rollebon was involved in the assassination of Paul I, but he suspects that "nothing can ever be proved."

The paragraph on the Marquis de Rollebon suggests that the Marquis lived a life full of interest and adventure, unlike Roquentin's own. It seems that Roquentin was motivated to write his book as a way of clinging to significance in his own life after he became disenchanted with travel, but his research is no longer doing the trick. His sustained interest in writing, however, foreshadows Nausea's ending. It also seems appropriate, given that he continues to write in his journal with some enthusiasm.



CHAPTER 7: FRIDAY

Roquentin lingers inside, disturbed by the harsh light of the sun. He dislikes the way the sun illuminates himself and the objects around him so clearly, leaving no ambiguities behind. Roquentin resolves to figure out whether Rollebon was involved in Paul I's assassination or not, but he quickly becomes bored and abandons his research. Roquentin looks at himself in a mirror without understanding his reflection, recognizing individual features of his face but finding the whole picture nonsensical. He twists and pulls at his face, disgusted by his softness, and he wonders if he fails to recognize himself because of his lack of friends.

Roquentin's inability to make sense of his reflection indicates an estrangement from his sense of self in broader terms. He can perceive the objective, individual details of his face, but when he tries to interpret them all together as an image of his face, he fails. In the same way, he understands some of the facts that make him who he is, but he can't put them together into a cohesive identity. The harsh light of the sun leaves no room for ambiguity, which heightens Roquentin's angst as his Nausea begins to direct itself inward.



CHAPTER 8: 5.30

Roquentin goes to the Rendezvous des Cheminots to see Françoise, but when he arrives, a waitress named Madeleine tells him that she's not there. Roquentin, dazed and disappointed, becomes lost in "the Nausea," his name for his affliction. Through a mental fog, Roquentin observes a group of men playing cards at a nearby table. He asks Madeleine to play his favorite record, and as the music begins, Roquentin starts to feel happy. He relishes the arrival of the vocal chorus, which feels inevitable and "necessary" to him. When the chorus does start, Roquentin's Nausea disappears and is replaced by a sort of euphoria.

Roquentin's Nausea becomes worse when he's thwarted from having sex with Françoise, a reaction that implies that his loneliness is one of the Nausea's causes. Again, he observes a group of people from the outside looking in, which only underlines his aloneness more starkly. For the first time, however, he finds a new source of comfort: music. While the song is playing, Roquentin feels a heightened awareness of time as he experiences it. This leads him to think of the chorus as inevitable and necessary, and indeed, the vocal line specifically seems to temporarily cure him of his Nausea.



When the music stops, Roquentin feels disquieted again and leaves the café. The fresh air and solid stone streets make him feel a little better. As Roquentin walks down the Boulevard Noir, he observes the city around him closely. Eventually, he reaches a fence plastered with old posters and stops in a pocket of darkness between streetlights and storefronts. Although there are people drinking, playing cards, and travelling the streets nearby, there is nobody in Roquentin's immediate surroundings. The "purity" of his aloneness soothes him.

Roquentin frequently walks the streets of Bouville while he seeks meaning and escape. In this instance, he seems relieved by the pocket of solitude he finds in the busy city. With fewer people and objects around, Roquentin has fewer existences to process. Because of this, he equates emptiness with purity (a lack of existence, or existence unencumbered by essence). Roquentin struggles with his contradictory urges: he's lonely and wishes for genuine companionship, but other people disgust him.



A man and a woman enter the scene, yelling at each other. As Roquentin passes the woman, he realizes that it's Lucie, and that the man is her husband, Charles. Charles snaps at her to be quiet, and Lucie begs him to come back as he walks away. Lucie looks at Roquentin without seeming to recognize him as he passes her. As Roquentin watches Lucie suffer, she stands still and touches her throat. Roquentin muses that Lucie seems like stone, matching the street setting full of hard and inanimate objects. As he leaves, he finds that he envies Lucie for the passion of her pain compared to his own "empty purity."

Lucie's failure to recognize Roquentin parallels his earlier inability to recognize the Self-Taught Man, but their emotional states are not the same. Rather than feeling Roquentin's apathetic Nausea, Lucie feels overwhelmed by the sheer weight of how much she feels. The encounter suggests that even if Roquentin had a real companion to confide in—Anny, Françoise, or someone else—it likely still wouldn't make his life happy or meaningful. Lucie's tendency to touch her throat when feeling grief also again calls to mind the man with the neck tumor from Roquentin's childhood memories. Like this man, Lucie is an example of someone who stands on the "outside." Where the man is on the outside of the crowd of children and Roquentin often seems to be on the outside of all society, Lucie is on the outside of her own marriage.



CHAPTER 9: TUESDAY, 11.30

Roquentin works on his research at the reading room and then takes a break in front of the library to smoke his pipe. As he smokes, Roquentin watches people pass by a bronze statue of Gustave Impétraz. He muses that the passersby don't engage with the statue on a deep level—they just glance at it and assume that someone as important looking as Impétraz must have shared their own views. One old woman, however, pauses to look fearfully at the statue before she goes on her way. When Roquentin himself looks at the statue, he suspects that Impétraz wants to drive him away. Encountering the Self-Taught Man, Roquentin exchanges a few awkward words with him before the two return to the library together.

Roquentin's description of the public's engagement with the statue of Impétraz encapsulates one of Sartre's arguments about existence and essence. The people passing by the statue don't even look at the statue itself. Instead, they only think of their own interpretation of the statue's significance, which they're naturally inclined to make flattering to themselves. In this way, people become increasingly removed from the existence, or bare truth, of things. Roquentin's own reaction to the statue follows the earlier patterns of his encounters with the stone and the piece of paper: he feels repulsed by it because it confronts him with the fact of its existence.



CHAPTER 10: 3.00 P.M.

Roquentin half-heartedly returns to his research. Noticing the Self-Taught Man admiringly watching him write, Roquentin looks at the books the Self-Taught Man is reading and realizes that he's working his way through the entire library in alphabetical order. Roquentin is impressed with the Self-Taught Man's resolve. He imagines the day the Self-Taught Man began his undertaking, as well as the day when it will end, picturing the Self-Taught Man finishing his last book and asking himself, "Now what?"

As Roquentin's own reason for living is losing its appeal, he starts to notice the Self-Taught Man's own search for meaning. The Self-Taught Man is a foil to Roquentin in this regard. After all, Roquentin spent six years of his life pursuing meaning by travelling the world and walking through foreign streets, while the Self-Taught Man's experience is entirely contained within the dusty Bouville reading room. A well-read man himself, Roquentin still seems skeptical of how effective the Self-Taught Man's approach can be. The Self-Taught Man will eventually run out of books and outside opinions to consult, and his life will ultimately be meaningless again.



CHAPTER 11: FRIDAY, 3.00 P.M.

Roquentin stands at the reading-room windows and watches the frightened-looking old woman from the square walk by again. As he watches her, time seems to slow, and moments blend together. Roquentin becomes lost in memories of his travels. As he thinks of the past, he realizes that he can't separate memory and imagination anymore. In some places, his memories have also disappeared or become confusing to him. Roquentin picks up a picture of a woman and stares at her without recognition before turning it over and seeing that it's labelled "Anny."

The old woman passing the statue of Impétra prompts Roquentin to reflect on the nature of time itself. As he watches her, he stops thinking of time in terms of objective measures and instead experiences it in subjective moments. It seems likely that it's the woman's visible old age that inspires his thoughts. Since she's as repulsed by the statue as he is, he starts to compare himself to her, and he perhaps imagines himself growing old, too. But Roquentin's mind is so confused and awash in apathy that he can't even sort out his own memories, rendering the passage of time almost meaningless.



The Self-Taught Man asks Roquentin to show him pictures from his travels, calling Roquentin lucky for the opportunity he's had to learn about the world firsthand. As Roquentin flips through photographs, the Self-Taught Man reacts excitedly, trying to connect each picture to facts he's learned through his reading. The Self-Taught Man admits that he longs to travel and have adventures. When he asks Roquentin if he has had any adventures himself, Roquentin's first impulse is to say yes—but he suddenly feels as though he's never had an adventure at all. "Things have happened to me," Roquentin muses, "[...] But no adventures." He begins to think he never will have an adventure, and he wonders why.

The contrast between Roquentin's and the Self-Taught Man's methods of education is on display in this interaction. Even when perusing Roquentin's photographs of his travels, the Self-Taught Man's urge is to find references for Roquentin's lived experiences in his own theoretical reading. Again, Roquentin appears very passive here, considering even his wide-ranging travels things that simply happened to him, as if he were never in control of them.



CHAPTER 12: SATURDAY NOON

In the library, Roquentin sees the Self-Taught Man watching a student from afar. Roquentin returns to the notion of adventure. He theorizes that something doesn't become an adventure until it's told as a story. While an adventure is happening, it blends in with the rest of time, and it doesn't feel special at all. It's only once the adventure has ended that it can have a "beginning." Roquentin goes on to say that all stories take on significance because of the listeners' awareness of the end, which makes every moment of the story feel important. He writes that he wants his life to have the significance and "order" of a memory in the present moment, which is impossible.

The Self-Taught Man's discreet attention to the student foreshadows the end of his character arc in the last few entries of the diary. Roquentin's argument about the meaning of adventure again highlights the subjective experience of time. He suggests that events become significant only relative to one another, and only from particular perspectives. Roquentin's reasoning also indicates that a "listener" of some sort is necessary to make adventures meaningful—a striking idea, given that Roquentin himself has no one to whom he can tell stories. This argument highlights the framing narrative of Nausea as Roquentin's published diaries. After all, Roquentin actually does have a listener, and he is presenting the events of the journal as a story, even if he doesn't yet know it.



CHAPTER 13: SUNDAY

In the morning, Roquentin sets out on a long walk. He imagines the crowds of people preparing to walk into the city for church. As he turns onto the Rue Tournebride, he joins a mass of other men walking. Roquentin considers the history of buildings and shops as he passes them. Noticing that the president of the Chamber of Commerce is walking next to him, Roquentin also starts to observe the people around him. Stopping for dinner, Roquentin tries to read a book, but finds himself continually absorbed in the gossip and flirtation of a husband and wife at a nearby table. Roquentin leaves the restaurant and starts to walk again.

Roquentin strolls down the Rue Bressan, observing the rhythms of the people around him. Thinking himself free to do as he pleases, Roquentin turns to walk toward the sea, a “puddle of light.” He realizes that the working-class crowd around him is resting on their one day off, while he is restlessly driving forward. Observing couples, children, and young women looking at the sky and sea, Roquentin briefly feels fond of the people surrounding him before he reminds himself that he stands apart from them. Suddenly, Roquentin senses a call to adventure and begins walking toward the Sainte-Cécile.

Happy and purposeful, Roquentin reaches out and touches a milestone in the street. He feels a self-awareness that’s at once the same as the Nausea and the opposite of it. Sensing more calls to adventure, Roquentin struggles with whether to proceed to the Place Ducoton or to try going through the Passage Gillet. Ultimately, he decides to go to the Place Ducoton. When he arrives, he makes his way to the full Café Mably and looks through its windows. He sees a female cashier inside and feels suddenly that time has stopped, and that his day has become meaningful in a moment of happiness. Later, Roquentin walks the Boulevard de la Redoute with a feeling of regret, wondering if his brief flashes of adventure are signs that he has wasted his life.

Today, Roquentin seems to try to blend into the rhythms of those around him as he joins the crowd of people walking through the city. Unlike those around him, though, Roquentin doesn’t have any real destination at the end of his walk. He strolls just to stroll and observe, embodying the modernist concept of a “flâneur,” or a gentleman who walks through a city at leisure. Again, Roquentin takes particular notice of the couples he encounters. Here, he seems to grow either disgusted or envious with the husband and wife’s companionship, which drives him to leave.



The language in this section, including Roquentin’s description of the sea, grows increasingly impressionistic as he breaks the city landscape down into its component parts. Roquentin’s thought process sheds some light on his persistent sense of solitude during the week. He can only join this crowd of working-class people on the street today because it’s Sunday, the only day of the week that the whole city has off from work. It’s a helpful reminder that Roquentin is a member of a higher socioeconomic class, and it suggests that his lack of work could be one reason why his life seems to lack meaning and adventure. For Roquentin, every day is roughly the same.



Roquentin’s contact with the milestone contrasts with his inability to touch the stone by the sea at the beginning of the novel. It’s unclear where exactly Roquentin’s brief, manic sense of adventure comes from, but it seems related to his consciousness of time passing. After all, walking in the crowd has made him particularly aware that today is Sunday. This leads him to feel aware of his own place within the context of the city and the world, too. It’s also unclear what exactly happens to Roquentin between looking at the cashier and walking back to his hotel. The omission highlights both the subjectivity of time itself and the fallibility of Roquentin as a narrator.



CHAPTER 14: MONDAY

Roquentin looks back on the previous night with disgust at his own enthusiasm. He reflects on the meaning of adventure, suggesting that it comes from the awareness of time's passage and irreversibility. Roquentin remembers going to see a movie with Anny on the night before they parted ways for three months. Knowing that Roquentin was to leave at midnight, Anny took his hand at eleven o'clock, and Roquentin became aware of every minute passing. At midnight, he left, and neither of them said a word to the other.

Roquentin's definition of adventure explains how he connects the concept of adventure to the idea of a meaningful life: when a person is aware of time slipping away, it makes every moment more important and special to them. He doesn't say so outright, but his remembrance of parting ways with Anny in this section implies that he sees the ending of their relationship as another adventure. Possibly, the end of Roquentin and Anny's relationship was the last time when he felt his life was meaningful.



CHAPTER 15: 7.00 P.M.

Roquentin writes a few pages on the Marquis de Rollebon, trying to keep a tight hold on his feelings after the excess of emotion he experienced on Sunday. He is growing increasingly tired of Rollebon. Roquentin feels frustrated with his inability to understand the Marquis completely or verify details of his life. He allows himself to imagine Rollebon, filling out the details of his personality in his mind. Roquentin realizes that this is a pointless exercise, however, since his work is based on research rather than imagination.

Roquentin's work continues to grow less and less meaningful and satisfying for him. At this point, he begins to get frustrated with the limitations of his scholarly discipline. He has been interested in the Marquis as an idea, but as a historian, he's forced to try to understand the Marquis as a person. In other words, his work deals with existence, but he finds his mind more often straying to the essence of the Marquis.



CHAPTER 16: 11.00 P.M.

Roquentin visits Françoise at the Rendezvous des Cheminots and kisses her through a feeling of disgust. As he touches her genitals, his mind wanders to the prospect of writing a novel about the Marquis de Rollebon. Roquentin's hand moves to Françoise's thigh, and he begins to imagine a dense **garden** full of insects and horrifying hybrid animals. Seeing a woman pointing between her legs, Roquentin shouts at her that the garden smells like vomit. Then, the woman wakes him up, telling him that she has to leave.

Although Roquentin has previously scolded himself for his flights of fancy, he grows increasingly interested in the prospect of writing non-historical literature. Here, his preoccupation with the idea underlines his apathy toward Françoise. Moreover, though, he becomes utterly disgusted by her sexuality in this section. His intense reaction seems like a symptom of his mounting dislike of the superficiality of their relationship, in which they have sex without any actual intimacy. Roquentin is, after all, frequently disturbed by facades and disguises. The imagery that he chooses perhaps also indicates disgust at Françoise's femininity and promiscuity, since the thick garden sounds a lot like pubic hair, and the scuttling insects and foul smell call to mind STIs.



CHAPTER 17: SHROVE TUESDAY

Roquentin receives a letter from Anny. In it, she tells him that she will be in Paris in a few days' time. She begs him to come see her while she's there. Roquentin is not excited at the thought of reuniting with Anny. Still, he reminisces about Anny's obsession with perfect moments. While Roquentin is having lunch at a restaurant, a small man named Achille comes in and begins to antagonize the waitress. Roquentin feels an uncomfortable kinship with Achille's restless and lonely manner. To the relief of both the waitress and Roquentin, Doctor Rogé enters the restaurant. He sizes Achille up and calls him "crazy." Even Achille seems relieved to be summed up so neatly, but the incident prompts Roquentin to reflect on how some men hide behind the authority of "experience." He concludes that, in actuality, Achille is afraid of something, and Doctor Rogé will soon die.

Roquentin has been thinking about Anny for a while, but when things finally progress, it's because of her action, not his. Again, Roquentin seems only capable of passively experiencing his life. At the restaurant, Achille joins the man with the neck tumor, Lucie, and the old woman walking by the statue on the list of people with whom Roquentin briefly identifies. Like the others, Achille is a bit of an outcast, immediately causing trouble with the waitress. Roquentin is frustrated with Achille's contentment at being labelled by Doctor Rogé due to both the act of labelling itself (which privileges essence) and due to his apparent jealousy of the social ease that comes with Doctor Rogé's experience.



CHAPTER 18: WEDNESDAY

Roquentin writes a one-line entry: "I must not be afraid."

Roquentin's fear of his own mind grows, but he's still unwilling to process that fear.



CHAPTER 19: THURSDAY

In another short entry, Roquentin writes four more pages of his book. He tries to avoid thinking about his work becoming "the only justification for [his] existence," and finds his thoughts wandering to Anny again.

In this entry, Roquentin starts to articulate an issue that has been interfering with his work on the Marquis. The Marquis's life has begun to replace his own, and the only meaning in his life is dependent on a historical figure. It looks like Roquentin is beginning to think of replacing the Marquis with Anny as a vessel of significance.



CHAPTER 20: FRIDAY

A thick **fog** blankets the city. Roquentin makes his way to Café Mably. An old woman enters the café looking for Monsieur Fasquelle, but the waiter tells her that he is still upstairs. Before she leaves, the old woman wonders aloud if Fasquelle is dead. Roquentin begins to imagine walking up the stairs and finding Fasquelle's dead body. When he finally stands, the waiter sees him, and Roquentin quickly tells him that he heard a choking noise from upstairs. He tries to convince the waiter to check on Fasquelle himself. The waiter is concerned, but he doesn't go upstairs, and Roquentin leaves.

The fog over Bouville corresponds to Roquentin's mental state, which is particularly scrambled and hazy in this entry. Perhaps as a result, Roquentin seems to be particularly suggestible as he starts to dwell on the possibility of Monsieur Fasquelle's death. His imagination starts to take the place of his observations of reality, and he becomes an increasingly unreliable narrator.



Taking to the streets again, Roquentin now believes Fasquelle dead, and his thoughts turn to images of blood. At the library, Roquentin encounters the Self-Taught Man, who asks him to lunch. Although he doesn't want to, Roquentin accepts. As he works, he notices that the reading room guard, a Corsican man, seems as though he wants to tell him something, but he never does. Roquentin keeps thinking of Fasquelle, and the room around him feels less and less real. Finally, Roquentin rushes back to Café Mably, but no one is there when he arrives. He panics and runs through the streets, staring at his surroundings as if to stop them from changing shape.

Roquentin starts back toward the library, passing a man in a cape that he has seen twice earlier today. As Roquentin passes, the man in the cape starts smiling, and Roquentin stops to observe. The man stands up and starts to walk toward a little girl, who stares back at him without surprise as he starts to take hold of his cloak. Suddenly, though, the man sees Roquentin, and the girl runs away. Roquentin only warns the man that “a great menace weighs over the city” and leaves. Back at the reading room, the Corsican guard ushers reluctant patrons out of the library at closing time. Roquentin is loath to go outside, but when he does, he finds that it's raining and the **fog** is gone.

The barrier between possibility and reality seems completely obliterated in Roquentin's mind now. As the fog persists, Roquentin's grasp on existence itself grows less and less steady. Roquentin's acceptance of the Self-Taught Man's invitation, much like his acceptance of Anny's commands via letter, again reflects his passive approach to his own life. The Corsican guard's behavior foreshadows the reveal of the Self-Taught Man's predilections at the end of Roquentin's diary for a second time.



The man in the cape seems like just another relatively insignificant part of Roquentin's surroundings, until he isn't. In reality, Bouville (and by extension, the world) is full of people who are troubled or unstable, like both Roquentin and the man in the cape. Roquentin notes pedophilia and sexual violence as if part of the landscape of Bouville several times, and this is one of those instances: the man in the cape intends to flash the little girl. The little girl's initially challenging gaze might be read in two different ways: first, it might suggest that she's so young and innocent that she has no idea what the man intends to do. It could also suggest (in Roquentin's subjective understanding) she's a tiny bit complicit in his bad behavior. Given the sympathy toward sex offenders that Roquentin demonstrates throughout parts of the remainder of the novel, both interpretations seem possible. The menace that Roquentin refers to is similarly ambiguous, but it might well refer to the fog that still lingers over the city. Speaking in such a veiled way, Roquentin seems just as crazy as the flasher, suggesting their shared nonconformity.



CHAPTER 21: SATURDAY MORNING

Roquentin has breakfast at the Café Mably. There, he learns that Fasquelle has the flu and that his daughter is on her way to look after him. For the first time, Roquentin feels excited to see Anny in Paris. He wonders if he can persuade her to stay at least a night with him in Bouville, imagining that if she did, his fear would go away.

After the fog has dissipated, Roquentin is able to view the world more clearly, and his intense paranoia surrounding Fasquelle has abated. At this point, he has begun to view Anny as the next possible solution to his Nausea and Loneliness, even though he initially didn't really want to meet her in Paris at all.



CHAPTER 22: AFTERNOON

Roquentin goes to the Bouville museum to see a portrait of Olivier Blévine, which he remembers looking odd. Near the entrance, he looks at a painting of a bachelor who died alone and reflects on what it means to live a life of self-gratification without significant relationships to other people. Marrying, having children, and leading others, Roquentin muses, is what gives the rest of the portraits in the hall the “right” to exist. Roquentin examines the other portraits and dwells upon how they spent their lives in meaningful ways. He thinks that he himself lacks the “right” to existence that the subjects of the portraits have. A couple enters the museum and comments on the awkwardness of the Blévine portrait. Roquentin realizes that because of Blévine’s short stature, the proportions of his portrait look awkward compared to the portrait next to him. Disgusted with his surroundings, he leaves.

The portraits in the museum are all immortalizations of existences, representations of people that last far beyond the actual lifespans of those involved. Roquentin’s struggle in this section comes from his difficulty in grappling with what gives people the right to exist while alive, much less after they die. What makes someone deserving of a legacy? In his musings, Roquentin supposes that, conventionally, being a credit to society (caring for a wife and children, serving the nation, etc.) is what validates someone’s existence and earns them a spot on the portrait wall. Roquentin, who spends his days walking aimlessly around the city and giving up on his esoteric historical research, has done no such thing, and this forces him to confront the possibility that he has no inherent right to life at all.



CHAPTER 23: MONDAY

Roquentin feels unable to continue his work on Rollebon. He reflects that he has given his own life and existence in order to preserve Rollebon’s. Looking at his own writing, Roquentin feels sure that the past itself does not exist and that the world of “existing” things extends only to what is present and visible. He struggles to imagine the face of Rollebon, and when he manages it, it still doesn’t feel “real” anymore. Released from his obligation to Rollebon, Roquentin suddenly becomes agonizingly aware of his own existence.

Finally, Roquentin gives up on the Marquis entirely. His experience in the portrait museum, where he dwells on the discrepancies between what existed and what is depicted on canvas, seems to inspire this decision. After all, Roquentin is like a portraitist of Roquentin, trying to pin down the facts of his existence, but as he grows increasingly aware of the difference between existence and essence, he doesn’t want to blend the two anymore.



As Roquentin walks through the streets, the rest of the entry dissolves into stream-of-consciousness narration. Thinking of his own flesh, he starts to dwell on the news story of a child rape victim and think of himself in the third person. He conflates himself alternately with the rapist and the child. Finally, Roquentin reaches a brothel, where music is playing on a gramophone. When he hears the voice of the singer, Roquentin feels “the world of existence” drop away. He supposes that the music in its current form does not exist, even though it was produced by things that do exist.

Awareness of his existence becomes excruciating for Roquentin, particularly as he’s recently begun to come to terms with the possibility that he has no reason for existing. Thinking of his existence itself as a crime, he confuses himself with the rapist in the news story. At the same time, however, he thinks of existence as a violence forced on him, confusing himself with the child. Roquentin’s relief in the nonexistence of music seems to stem from the ephemerality and intangible nature of the medium compared to other art forms like sculpture and portraiture.



CHAPTER 24: TUESDAY

Roquentin records a very short entry: “Nothing. Existed.”

This entry is open for interpretation: did Roquentin do nothing today, or did nothing worthy of continued “existence” in the journal entry happen? Perhaps Roquentin is struggling again with intense derealization.



CHAPTER 25: WEDNESDAY

Roquentin meets the Self-Taught Man for lunch. The Self-Taught Man alludes to a problem he's having with the Corsican guard, but he trails off before saying what it is. A young couple enters the restaurant, and Roquentin feels disgusted by their apparent affection for one another. Reflecting on how everyone in the room is avoiding confronting their own existence, Roquentin starts to laugh. When the Self-Taught Man questions him, Roquentin admits that he thinks there is no reason to exist, and the two enter a philosophical conversation. The Self-Taught Man, a humanist, tries to convince Roquentin that even in the absence of God, people give life meaning. He tells Roquentin that after being taken prisoner in a crowded camp during World War I, he fell in love with humankind, ultimately becoming both a humanist and a Socialist.

The Self-Taught Man presses Roquentin to disclose his motivation for writing his book and asks him to label himself. Roquentin uncomfortably admits that he writes only to write and that he's opposed to humanism and all of the other labels that the Self-Taught Man suggests. He feels that humanism engages with humankind only shallowly, contradicting itself in its acceptance of all types of people and undermining itself in its treatment of humans as symbols. The Self-Taught Man tries to insist that Roquentin loves humanity at heart, but Roquentin is overtaken by a strong bout of Nausea and leaves the restaurant abruptly. The other patrons watch him judgmentally as he exits.

Roquentin makes his way down the street, comparing himself to a **crab** among men. He muses that the existence of God is merely a "veneer" covering the true existence of all else. In a daze, Roquentin boards a tram and examines the seat next to him. He finds that the objects around him confront him with their existence, but he can't attach them to their names or meanings. Roquentin rushes off the tram and to a park, where he sits, feeling suffocated. Suddenly, however, he has a realization.

Roquentin and the Self-Taught Man's initial conversation foreshadows the Self-Taught Man's secret again. Roquentin continues to struggle with seeing couples in public places, and in this section, seeing a couple seems to prompt his reflection on his own lack of meaning. Notably, the philosophical conflict between Roquentin and the Self-Taught Man starts with the mutual assumption that there is no God. Neither Roquentin nor the Self-Taught Man believes that a higher deity endows humans with essence, but both men are concerned with other possibilities for the meaning of life. Generally, this conversation is representative of the debate between Existentialists (or at least Sartre) and humanists. It's also striking that the Self-Taught Man has travelled and adventured perhaps more than he initially let on—after all, he fought in World War I. He has also dedicated his life to a higher purpose in a way that Roquentin has not, which seems to partially form his humanist perspective.



Again, Roquentin is wary of names and labels, which often obscure the bare existence of the things they describe. Roquentin's dislike of humanism comes from the same impulse: he dislikes reducing things to their essence, which he believes humanism does in order to sustain itself. The Self-Taught Man's attempt to reassure Roquentin that he loves humanity echoes Roquentin's own effort to love the crowd of people he walked with on Sunday, but Roquentin still is unable to come to grips with the idea of loving so abstractly.



Roquentin is excruciatingly self-aware again, and his paranoia at people observing him as he transgresses social norms manifests in visions of himself as a shamefaced, scuttling crab. His thoughts on God place God in the position of essence, something that obscures existence in an effort to explain and justify it.



CHAPTER 26: 6.00 P.M.

Sitting in the **garden**, Roquentin understands the true nature of Existence. Suddenly, everything that he's experienced makes sense to him. He feels more comfortable with the Nausea, now considering it an extension of himself. Roquentin realizes that existence is absolute, specific, and unconstrained by meaning or description. Roquentin's initial ecstasy at his revelation gives way to repulsion as he becomes overwhelmed by the weight of existence surrounding him. He doesn't see existence as something won, created, or fought for. Rather, he perceives every existing thing as "born without reason, prolong[ing] itself out of weakness and [dying] by chance." Roquentin feels angry and dirtied by this realization of the world. Deciding that he's learned all he can for the moment, he leaves.

At first, Roquentin is excited to finally understand his condition—but once he realizes what it is, he's no longer happy at all. The passage suggests that in order to become enlightened about the meaning of life, one must come to terms with the possibility that one's own life is meaningless. Existentialism posits that while existence is a condition that's worthwhile or meaningful in itself, humans can make their lives worthwhile and meaningful through their choices. Here, Roquentin has grappled with the first part of this teaching, but not the second.



CHAPTER 27: NIGHT

Feeling that he has no reason to remain in Bouville after giving up his research on Rollebon, Roquentin resolves to move to Paris after his visit to Anny.

The ease with which Roquentin makes this decision indicates his wealth as well as his lack of meaningful ties to Bouville, the city he's lived in for a while now. Still, Roquentin is making a decision, even if he makes it in order to blindly follow the hope offered by Anny's letter.



CHAPTER 28: FRIDAY

While waiting for his train to Paris at the Rendezvous des Cheminots, Roquentin listens to music from the gramophone and feels a sense of adventure.

Roquentin receives a sense of adventure from the feeling of doing something. He's on the precipice of a change, which is invigorating after his months of stagnation in Bouville.



CHAPTER 29: SATURDAY

Roquentin visits Anny. Entering her hotel room, he's immediately struck by how bare it is; as he remembers, Anny always carries a trunk full of masks and shawls to decorate her rooms. Anny herself looks different, too: older, fatter, and more tired. She gleefully tells Roquentin that he hasn't changed since they last spoke six years ago. Anny divulges that she uses Roquentin's fixed nature as a milestone against which she can judge her own transformation. She admits that she has quit the theater, that she is a "kept woman" to an older man, and that she no longer experiences the "perfect moments" that used to motivate her.

Anny's masks and shawls suit her old profession as an actor; they're made to cover and beautify the things they touch. In Roquentin's memories, Anny herself likewise tries to make every moment as perfect as it can be. The fact that she has packed up her decorations and quit the theater aligns with her inability to experience perfect moments any longer, suggesting that Anny is also beginning to confront the bare existence that lies underneath essence.



Roquentin asks Anny to elaborate, and she describes a state of mind that's similar to Roquentin's Nausea. Anny used to conceive of "privileged situations," rare scenarios that create the potential for a perfect moment. Her relationship with Roquentin was one of Anny's privileged situations, but Roquentin generally failed to predict what response he should give to make moments perfect for Anny. Now, however, Anny feels apathy toward the abstract ideas that characterize privileged situations, finding it pointless to differentiate between them. Roquentin, excited at her description's resemblance to his own struggles with adventure and existence, tells her everything he's experienced.

Anny asks Roquentin what his reason for living is now, and he can only answer by telling her about the happiness music brings him. Anny admits that she copes by living in the past as much as possible, revising her memories to be perfect moments and reminiscing to pass the time. Still, she's dissatisfied with this solution. Roquentin and Anny sit for a moment in silence before Anny directs Roquentin to leave. He offers to visit again tomorrow, but she declines. Anny kisses Roquentin one more time for memory's sake. She pulls away and congratulates him for finally creating a perfect moment, then shuts the door on him.

CHAPTER 30: SUNDAY

Roquentin entertains thoughts of convincing Anny to live with him in Paris. He checks her train's departure time and passes the time looking at pornographic books while he waits. Time passes quickly, and Roquentin makes it to the train station in time to see Anny and her partner board. The man is young, tan, and foreign. Anny silently locks eyes with Roquentin until the train leaves. Unhappily, Roquentin goes to a café and falls asleep. When he wakes up, he prepares to leave for Bouville the following day and wonders if moving to Paris will help his situation at all.

CHAPTER 31: TUESDAY, IN BOUVILLE

Roquentin's encounter with Anny marks the end of his efforts to find a reason to live. He dwells on his utter freedom and loneliness, thinking that his life has effectively come to an end. Roquentin climbs to the top of a hill and looks down at Bouville, feeling like a total stranger compared to the people going about their predictable, working-class lives below. Their lives follow a pattern and schedule, but Roquentin conceives of a threat lurking in the city. He imagines what would happen if it took hold and everyone in Bouville felt the way he has, entertaining grotesque visions of body parts becoming insects and pimples becoming extra eyes. He compares himself to Cassandra, unable to warn the city of what might come.

After months of cataloging the strangest figures he sees in Bouville, Roquentin has finally found someone whose predicament perfectly mirrors his own. Anny's concept of perfect situations cleaves to his theory of adventure in the sense that the irreversibility of time is an important component. Having aged, both Roquentin and Anny find the days blurring together without significance. More than ever, he seems to wonder if a partnership with Anny would ease his own Nausea.



Roquentin's best solution to the Nausea is to live in the present, while Anny's is to live in the past. All in all, Roquentin seems to be closer to a genuine breakthrough than Anny is. Still, she's resigned to her life as it is. Unlike Roquentin, she doesn't appear to have seriously entertained the possibility of rekindling their relationship. The failure of Roquentin's efforts indicates that the solution to a meaningless life is not to hide in the embrace of another person; instead, one has to justify their existence independently.



Roquentin spends his entire day waiting to catch Anny at the train station, only to stand passively by and watch her leave. Although neither he nor Anny is precisely happy, they both have become resigned to the fact that they can't make each other happy. Roquentin considers himself back at square one in his search for meaning.



Roquentin is just as free as he was at the beginning of the novel, but he now has a better understanding of what freedom means for humanity. With freedom comes the obligation to make choices that determine the meaning of one's life. Now, Roquentin observes the city from a new vantage point, and he imagines that the same hideous awareness of existence and its burden that he endured will eventually strike everyone in Bouville. As Roquentin imagines this, his warning to the man in the cape takes on new significance.



CHAPTER 32: WEDNESDAY: MY LAST DAY IN BOUVILLE

Roquentin prefaces his entry by professing his sympathy for the Self-Taught Man, whom he says has now entered permanent solitude. Earlier that day, Roquentin went to the reading room and started to read a local newspaper. He saw the Self-Taught Man, but he didn't seem to want to talk to Roquentin. As Roquentin read, two high school boys enter the room and sit next to the Self-Taught Man. Roquentin noticed that the boy sitting closest to the Self-Taught Man had an arrogant and mischievous expression. The Self-Taught Man began to whisper to the boys and stroke the arrogant-looking boy's hand. Roquentin felt worried that the Self-Taught Man would be caught if he wasn't careful, but the Self-Taught Man continued to touch the boy.

When the Self-Taught Man reached under the table to touch the boy further, the Corsican guard snuck up behind him and loudly threatened him. The Self-Taught Man tried to deny touching the boy, but a woman patron in the room backed the guard up, calling the Self-Taught Man a "monster." The Corsican guard hit the Self-Taught Man in the face twice. Roquentin saw gentleness and fear in the Self-Taught Man's eyes as he took the beating. Roquentin grabbed the guard and lifted him by the neck, but he let him go when the guard questioned him. Roquentin tried to help the Self-Taught Man tend to his wounds, but the Self-Taught Man fled into the city.

Roquentin wants his loyalty on record: despite the transgression and criminality of the Self-Taught Man's actions, he seems to be on his side instead of the young student's. In keeping with this position, Roquentin describes the student that the Self-Taught Man molests as goading the older man, as if the young boy is the pervert and the Self-Taught Man is the innocent. Roquentin's evaluation of the situation recalls his description of the encounter between the little girl and the man in the cape, in which the little girl seems to challenge the flasher with her eyes before she runs away.



Popular opinion is against the Self-Taught Man, but Roquentin appears sympathetic with his unconventional, transgressive desires. He portrays the Self-Taught Man almost as a martyr, particularly as he describes his eyes as he's being beaten. At this point, the Corsican guard's observation of the Self-Taught Man, the Self-Taught Man's reluctance to share the details of their conflict with Roquentin, and the Self-Taught Man's gaze at a student early in the novel make sense. All along, the Self-Taught Man has sought experience and adventure through one particular outlet: pedophilic molestation.



CHAPTER 33: ONE HOUR LATER

With two hours before his train is to depart, Roquentin walks through the city toward the Rendezvous des Cheminots. He feels as though Bouville is indifferent to him, as if it has forgotten him already. Only Roquentin is aware of his own existence, he muses. Drifting out of the first-person perspective, Roquentin dwells on consciousness itself. He thinks of the Self-Taught Man and Anny, imagining where they are now. Roquentin arrives at the Rendezvous des Cheminots and bids Françoise and Madeleine goodbye. Madeleine puts on Roquentin's favorite record, and he reflects on the purity and nonexistence of music. Roquentin imagines the song's composer and singer and has an idea: perhaps, if he creates something new, he can "justify" his own existence. Excited, Roquentin contemplates writing a novel as night falls on Bouville.

Despite living in Bouville for a while, Roquentin believes that he has made essentially no impression on the people there. Still, Françoise and Madeleine wish him a fairly warm goodbye, and Madeleine still remembers his favorite record. Between them and the fleeing Self-Taught Man, it seems like some people will remember Roquentin. As he listens to the record, Roquentin finally has a breakthrough. He realizes that if he creates a work of fiction, something removed from the dependence on existence that comes from a discipline like history, he can live on in some way as pure essence. Given that Roquentin's diary gets published by the nameless Editors at some point, it seems likely that he succeeded in his endeavor.





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